Eternian Amendments

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58154389.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra)

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Cheerleaders, Internalized Homophobia, Homophobia, Enemies to Lovers, Kind Of, conversion therapy, set the gays free, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Light Angst, Useless Lesbians, Eventual Romance, Manipulation, Fluff, Smut, Semi-Public Sex, Top Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Sex, Queer Themes, Romance, netossa and spinnerella are the best gay aunties, Alternate Universe - 1990s, Happy Ending, Religious Guilt, Ambiguous/Open Ending, ish

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by 1uxian

Summary

"When you see a woman, say, in a tight skirt, or perhaps in the locker room, in the showers..." Light Hope trailed off, looking at Adora expectantly who shifted uncomfortably and continuing gently when she didn't answer. "You don't have any... unnatural thoughts?"

"I don't think it's unnatural."

or

Adora gets more than she bargains for when she meets Catra at the conversion camp her parents sent her to in order to rid her of her so-called lesbianism. Though Adora still feels confused, her developing feelings make her problems so much worse.

Notes

Hellooo. In case you don't recognise from the summary, this fic is based on the movie "But I'm a Cheerleader" - a satirical teen romance comedy which I enjoyed, loved the plot and the whole idea of this story. Warnings for homophobia / conversion camp, it is not very harsh however still pretty obvious. Also themes of exploring gender roles / heteronormativity. That's all I think, enjoy

See the end of the work for more notes

Arrival

Adora Gray had the perfect life.

Perfect in all the ways an eighteen year old's high school life could possibly be. Perfect grades in every class which she seemed to effortlessly excel in, paired with a near perfect attendance rate. The perfect reputation at school, Bright Moon High's very own sweetheart. Perfect in her relationships with her long time friends, Bow, Glimmer and the others, and her boyfriend too. Perfect in her extracurriculars, and she was all too proud to avow her newly gained captainship of the cheerleading team of BMHS. Perfect familial circumstances at home, where it was just her and her perfectly loving mother and father.

Adora Gray liked to think about her life especially during cheer practice, when there was nothing between her and the wind whipping through the tight ponytail sat behind her head as she was tossed through the air in an organised manner. It was a freeing feeling, almost, not that she could ever come to any real conclusion as to what she was being freed from in the first place. Everything was going just fine, and she had next to nothing to complain about.

And so she didn't focus on that feeling so much as every other good thing in her life while at cheer practice.

Adora loved cheerleading. It wasn't normally something to be so passionate about, as far as a lot of people she'd spoken to about it thought. She was well aware her sport was seen by many as a mere supporting act for the 'main event' of the weekly football games, but she didn't mind. Her team's routine was a spectacle in itself, a thing she wholeheartedly believed could be enjoyed without having to be seen as a tacked on attraction to the guys' football. Of course that didn't deter her, however.

The pleasurable feeling of a satisfying burn in her arm muscles as she tossed and lifted her other teammates in a coordinated

routine along with the others, the unsteady wobble of standing on their shoulders just seconds before a jump or a flip, all of it - it felt as exhilarating as it looked to her. Her teammates were a huge factor in her love of the sport too, of course, having known them and trained with them since their freshmen year of BMHS and then recently having taken over as captain after Mara graduated. She was close with them, for sure, inside and outside of cheer. They were talented, of course, good at what they did and looked good while doing it. Adora certainly understood the outside appeal, anyway.

She quickly shook off the thought as she shifted the bag slipping off her shoulder to sit properly, leaning forward to look down the road, and sure enough she saw her ride parked on the pavement. With a sigh and a hand running over her head to smooth down any flyaways from her tightly tied hair, she made her way towards it. It was a familiar sight, the car of her boyfriend. An old, roughed up BMW which engine was much too loud and an interior almost always stinking of smoke.

She got in the passenger seat next to her patiently awaiting boyfriend as she always did after practice. Occasionally she considered asking him to stop waiting for her so she could walk home by herself instead, but quickly came to the conclusion that ingratitude was likely not the way to go. She didn't exactly feel unstable within her relationship, as it was generally smooth as a ship sailing in the nighttime. She usually ended up chalking her uneasiness up to the fact he was her first boyfriend and she wasn't confident in what she did. That must have been what it was, she thought, every day when she pursed her lips into a smile to subtly avoid the greeting kiss that was always awaiting her.

Every day he would drive Adora home to her loving mother and father, and that day was no different. He would greet her parents like how a good, respectable boyfriend should and then leave for the evening. It was a good system, it worked just fine for Adora, and that day should've really been no different, after all. However, once the front door closed behind her boyfriend her parents' easy smiles settled into more serious looks as they sat her down on the

couch in the silent living room where a man she'd never seen before in her life was already stood waiting.

She couldn't recall it quite right. She just knew it was a blur of an hour including a slideshow, her parents being way too nice about the situation than she'd rather they had been, and the man handing her a colourful brochure with the words Eternian Amendments in bold pink and blue letters on the cover.

That was how she ended up here, she supposed. Cramped up in the backseat of her parents' car with a small suitcase at her feet as she leaned her head against the window, thinking about all the events that had landed her in this situation which quite frankly she thought wrongful. Maybe she would've been able to find it in herself to be embarrassed about it if she wasn't feeling so much resentment for the adults in the front seats at the moment, practically jovial in their journey of shipping off their only daughter to a conversion camp - correction facility, as they had kindly put it - for a few weeks. Two months, to be exact.

Correction facility. Right. Adora could hardly believe it, had hardly even had time to process the words coming out of that man in her living room's mouth, who had turned out to be one of the camp's advertisers, before she found herself packed up and out of her home. She thought their "proof" to be awfully shallow too, honestly. So what she had posters of half unclothed women put up in her bedroom, they were athletes! That didn't make her a lesbian. Neither did her close female friendships or her physical diversion in regard to her boyfriend, neither her vegetarianism nor her interest in Melissa Etheridge. In any other circumstances, Adora may have reprimanded her parents for having such stereotypical presumptions about a person. She'd just never anticipated that person to be her of all people.

Not Adora. Not the golden girl. Perfect in every aspect of her life except this one, apparently. It was almost funny in a way, she herself had never given even a passing thought to her own sexuality, but her parents seemed to have taken care of that for her. She was displeased to say the least, but she decided to at

least try and find the light in this situation here, ever the optimist. The strange man in her living room as well as her parents had insisted Eternian Amendments was in fact a gentle correction facility rather than the type of harsh conversion camps she had learned about in school, so that was a start.

Adora was never considered herself to be a close minded person, not like some of the others at her school and her church. Or maybe she was. That would explain the uncomfortable feeling in the very pit of her stomach that entertained the idea that she may in fact not be as perfect as she'd thought herself to be. The sick, coiled up feeling always slightly eating away at her like termites at rotting wood that something wasn't right. Of course she never dwelled on it long enough to look into it seriously, but maybe this was it. Hopefully not, but there was always the chance.

The car drove over a rock or pothole of sorts, jolting the car and making Adora's head knock harshly against the window, snapping her out of that train of thought. A correction facility - she could work with that. The two month course suggested that there was likely a series of measures to make it through, so she would simply just have to follow the rules as she always did and make it out unscathed. Adora was and always had been an avid rule follower. She shouldn't be worried. She wasn't.

And she still wasn't worried when the small family car drove up a slightly hilled dirt rode until an unexpectedly friendly looking building came into view, with a fine flower garden in the front and three low steps leading up to the front door where a woman Adora could only describe as smart and tidy was already waiting. She got out of the car silently and dragged her small case with her, disregarding her parents attempts at helping her with it, and the three eventually reached the woman on the stairs.

"Hello and welcome, you must be Adora Gray," the woman greeted with a small smile, holding out a hand for Adora to shake, and she did. Adora briefly surveyed the woman in front of her while her hand was in an almost uncomfortably tight grip - the shortest hair she'd ever seen on a woman, neat clothes and the

exact kind of straight posture she'd expect for someone who looked as uptight as she did. "I hope your journey was well. My name is Light Hope, welcome to Eternian Amendments. Please come inside to my office right here, and I'll get you started."

Adora nodded silently as Light Hope spoke, hesitating as she watched her disappear behind the front door at the top of the steps. She followed her after a hasty goodbye to her parents, barely hearing them about a 'she seems nice, right?' before they were gone. Light Hope sat behind a large oak desk with a chair for Adora on the opposite side. It almost reminded Adora of the setup of the principal's office back at Bright Moon, although it wasn't as if she made very many trips there to begin with. She sat down in the uncomfortable plastic chair facing Light Hope as the woman pushed some sort of hospital gown resemblant garments towards her on the desk before speaking.

"Now, Adora. Luckily the others only arrived yesterday so I expect you should be able to catch up swiftly. As you know, this program will be lasting two months and you will graduate, ready and healed, by that time," Light Hope explained with a smile, clasping her hands together. Adora wasn't sure about her use of the word 'healed,' as if she already had an ailment that needed to be so. "There are five simple steps within the program, the first of which you will familiarise yourself with today - admitting that you have a problem."

Adora blinked dumbly at that, almost as if she'd completely forgotten what had landed her in that chair in the first place. A problem. Something not working quite right in her head that needed to be corrected... She still wasn't convinced, however, so allowed Light Hope to continue.

"When you see a woman, say, in a tight skirt, or perhaps in the locker room, in the showers..." Light Hope trailed off, looking at Adora expectantly who shifted uncomfortably in the hard plastic of her chair and continuing gently when she didn't answer. "You don't have any... unnatural thoughts?"

“I don’t think it’s unnatural,” Adora replied before she could stop herself - and probably incorrectly, judging by the suspiciously understanding expression on Light Hope’s face, as if she’d heard the same thing a thousand times beforehand. Sure, she’d had wandering thoughts in those situations before, but it was never anything she had entertained long enough to consider it a problem. Or a product of anything at all, really.

“There it is, don’t you see, Adora? You don’t even think that it’s wrong,” Light Hope nodded, patting her hands lightly on the garments she’d pushed forward on the desk earlier. “Until you admit your sickness, you will wear these. You will earn the right to wear our uniform once you have admitted the first step.”

Adora took the garments in her arms, the fabric of which certainly felt as uncomfortable against her skin as they looked. For every passing thought that maybe she did need to be here, came another slap in the face that perhaps this whole ordeal was a huge mistake materialised out of her own parents’ stereotypical views. Light Hope seemed to notice her discomfort and offered her another small smile. “It’s a long path to righteousness, Adora. And it’s a battlefield of temptation out there, and you’re going to have to fight. Until then, I’d like you to meet one of our other soldiers.”

Adora opened her mouth to respond but by then it was already too late, the door to the office swinging open from the new presence. She turned in her chair to see another girl who looked to be her age leaned against the wooden doorframe with a bored expression.

“Adora, this is Mermista,” Light Hope supplied, gesturing Adora to rise from her chair with a swift hand movement. “She will show you around. And you’ll get acquainted, of course. I will see you both later on.”

Shortly after the dismissal, Adora found herself following this girl out of the office and down a different path to where a few more motel looking buildings were along. The camp was nice, at least,

with some colourful flowers dotted around the greener areas and the outside walls looking sterile in an almost, but not quite, friendly way. That wasn't even the most colourful component of the place, Adora noted, with Mermista's uniform - pink shirt with an even hotter shade of pink skirt - being quite the eyeful as well.

"Day starts at seven thirty, breakfast at eight," Mermista droned on as she lead Adora down the path winding around one of the one-story flat-roofed buildings, seemingly absent minded as she rattled off the schedule. "Group therapy until lunch. Afternoon is just free time to do whatever, and then we move inside the north wing for reorienting exercises. Family therapy on the weekends. You didn't exactly miss anything, so."

"Oh, okay. That's... good," Adora responded unsurely as Mermista stopped right outside a brightly painted pink door, waiting for Adora to step inside first before coming in after her.

"This is where we sleep," Mermista sighed as she gestured vaguely around the room, a large communal space with four beds with pink sheets - Adora was also beginning to notice a recurring theme around here. It was a fine space, nothing to write home about, but she quickly noticed one of the beds was occupied with another pink-clad girl. Similarly to Mermista, she looked like the type of person to not be caught dead in getup like that anywhere outside of the camp, in which she supposed wasn't exactly a choice. "And there's no inappropriate behaviour allowed. Obviously."

"Inappropriate?" Adora parroted, quickly snapping her gaze away from the girl draped across one of the beds and flicking through a book, although to Adora it didn't seem like she was reading much at all. "Like...swearing?"

Her questioned immediately derived a half amused, half incredulous snort from the girl on the bed, and Adora could've sworn she heard Mermista rolling her eyes along with the poorly concealed groan under her breath. However Mermista wasn't the one who had already grasped her attention, as Adora's eyes were

drawn once again to the girl on the bed who had by now slammed her book shut.

"No. Inappropriate like fucking," the girl on the bed responded, the mirthful smirk adorning her face making Adora feel somewhat stupid. She had tan skin and sharp features and frankly quite beautiful eyes with two different shades of turquoise and amber, which Adora had never even considered possible. A thick mane of dark brown hair, too. Even in the ridiculous pink uniform Adora thought she could probably guess this girl's actual style if she tried. "You get caught in the throes of sodomy and it's bye bye, blondie."

Adora scoffed at that and opened her mouth to retaliate just before Mermista cut in with a groan and shook her head.

"That's Catra, don't bother with her. She's absolutely insufferable more often than not," she said, rolling her eyes at Catra's middle finger before gesturing to another door inside the room. "Bathroom's in there. Get changed, Light Hope wants us all inside for your first *disclosure* in five."

Adora made quick work of changing into the impressively uncomfortable garments she was given, and one look in the mirror told her she looked fit to be dressed for the psychiatric ward instead. It was a pale green colour and shapeless like a hospital gown, falling just about to her knees. She sighed and redid her ponytail, with only the promise of the impractical pink uniform awaiting her after her "first step" to keep her from tearing the garment off altogether.

When she emerged from the bathroom Catra was already gone, and so Adora followed Mermista to the next building over which she assumed was the north wing she heard about earlier. Once they got inside Adora noticed the interior was similar to the others - with a faint scent of cleaning chemicals wafting around the air and a general pristine glow about the place. One look around, however, made Adora notice the different setup in the centre of the room this time. More plastic chairs set in a semicircle now

occupied with who she could guess were the other unfortunate residents of Eternian Amendments, and an empty chair facing them.

Adora noticed the other two girls sitting there, including Catra and another she hadn't seen before, were all wearing the same pink getup as Mermista. Pink and impractical were the only two words that came to Adora's mind about them, but still better than whatever she had on. Adora noticed the boys there too, four of them, whose outfits consisted of blue shirts and deeper blue shorts. It made sense, she supposed - pink and blue, girls and boys. Organised in a way that should've felt natural and normal, although it just seemed unpleasant to Adora. Maybe that's why she was here, and her views would soon be changed. Maybe.

"Ah, Adora, why don't you take a seat right there," Light Hope spoke up from where she was standing behind most of the chairs, gesturing to the empty chair that was rather isolated away from the rest of them. Mermista brushed past her to go and take her own seat as Adora reluctantly took the one in the unasked for spotlight, offering herself up for everyone else to get a look at. "There's no need to be intimidated. How about we start with why you think you are here with us today?"

Adora hesitated for a few seconds as she thought about the question. She perhaps should have realised the lack of privacy she would be provided with living in such a communal space as this for two months, but it didn't ease her discomfort at all of the eyes on her, awaiting a suitable answer. What even brought her there in the first place, a couple of accusations?

"I'm - I'm not sure," Adora answered eventually, absently playing with her fingers in her lap as she kept her gaze on the floor or anywhere, really, away from the others. She knew she shouldn't feel ashamed or out of place considering everybody was there for the same reason, but she still did. "My parents told me they thought I was, well... a lesbian. I'm not sure I should even be here."

“That’s a perfectly normal place to start,” Light Hope nodded encouragingly, and Adora was only grateful she spoke so it wasn’t her own words that hung in the air around them. “We can discuss your intervention to help you along. Now, have you ever had a boyfriend?”

“Yes, I have, for almost a year now,” Adora responded, happy to finally have a question that she had a confident one-way answer to. As much as she didn’t like to admit it, she hadn’t exactly given him a thought since the whole intervention. Although, she supposed she missed him now. She should miss him.

“I really love him,” Adora continued, trying to make sure she sounded certain and sure and not as if she was attempting to convince herself, even as the words sounded hollow in her ears. “He’s smart, and popular...”

She heard Catra scoff at that, and Adora finally dragged her gaze up to see the girl in question rolling her eyes. Adora didn’t bother to feel too mad or upset yet, since she figured this was just the type of person Catra was. Not somebody who tried or took things seriously, Adora had met enough of them back at Bright Moon to be familiar with the type.

“Have you had sex with him, then?” Catra asked, her tone dry as she leaned back in her chair with an expression between unimpressed and amusement at being the cause of Adora’s discomfort. The only intervention from Light Hope was a disapproving click of her tongue, her arms folded across her chest.

“I’m a Christian,”Adora responded, returning Catra’s sharp gaze as she shifted slightly where she sat. She thought she could usually read people well, but even now Adora was sure of apparently none of Catra’s intentions apart from making her as uncomfortable as possible.

“It’s really easy to be a prude when you’re not attracted to him, isn’t it?” Catra hummed in response, her voice lowered and

smooth like honey as she leaned forward slightly towards Adora, who was right about to defend herself before being cut off. "Do you think about him, at night? When you - "

"Catra, that is quite enough out of you," Light Hope scolded with a sharp glare from where she stood. Catra simply scoffed in response, her back hitting the backrest of her chair once again as Adora stared her down.

"I'm not a pervert. I get good grades, I go to church, I..." Adora trailed off weakly, shrugging her shoulders in her last ditch attempt to explain herself. "I'm a cheerleader. I'm not like all of you."

"Adora," Light Hope began gently, the patience in her voice almost making the girl wince. "I know it may seem like it now, but you know that's not true. I understand you believe everyone looks at other girls, all the time. You only assume that they're thinking what you're thinking when they look. But they're not."

Adora's gaze was trained on Light Hope as she spoke now, the older woman's words sinking beneath her skin to be absorbed in her core with an unpleasant sharpness. A deeply rooted, sickening truth that threatened to rise to her realisation that Light Hope was, in fact, correct, and Adora's innocently wandering thoughts were not as innocent as she may have hoped them to be. That she was more unique in her way of thinking and her preferences than most, if not all people in her life. That her attracted strayed away to other girls rather than where it was supposed to be.

"But I thought everybody had those thoughts," Adora answered uncertainly, now wringing one of her hands in the other in her lap. She could feel the weight of everyone's gaze burning into her now more than ever, still refusing to meet anyone's eyes apart from Light Hope. "I just want to be normal."

"Then you admit you're not normal," Light Hope pushed, her eyebrows raised slightly now, almost encouraging the way in

which Adora was cracking now. “So why don’t you admit that you’re a homosexual?”

The words sounded like they were spoken a thousand miles a way, or underwater, and Adora was practically straining to understand them right even though she knew she hadn’t misheard. This was her first step after all, wasn’t it? She knew how easy it would be to suck it up and say the words, get into some proper clothes, have everyone’s eyes to stop burning into her existence, receive the adequate help that she was sent here to receive in the first place. She sat rigid in her plastic chair, her heart racing and the hairs on the back of her neck stood up as the words got caught in her throat briefly before she sucked in a breath and quickly spat them out. “I’m a homosexual.”

“Congratulations, Adora,” Light Hope said with a flourishing smile, her arms falling out of her tight crossing as she clapped her hands together once instead. “You have just taken your first step towards your amendment!”

Adora looked up from the floor hesitantly, as if she had expected her whole world to have crumbled to the ground around her after the admission, only to be instantly proven wrong. There was an echo of half hearted applause from the other inhabitants, from all apart from Catra, of course. Adora didn’t even find herself caring, mostly just relieved to get that peculiar sentence out of her system and into the air. So much so that it took her a moment to blink back into focus when somebody dumped a neatly folded pink uniform set on her lap.

“Okay, head on out now for lunch,” Light Hope said with a dismissive wave of her hand as the others immediately stood up from their seats and Adora unsurely following suit. She felt somebody knocking against her shoulder as they walked by and didn’t even have to look to know it was Catra.

Still. She wouldn’t let one bad tempered girl get in the way of her progress towards graduating the camp. She’d never let anyone

get in her way like that before, and she certainly did not intend to start now.

Family

Chapter Notes

> Please be aware of the warnings for this chapter - use of the F slur and more in-your-face homophobia. As well as that, physical abuse is heavily implied so be careful of that too. Other than that and possibly a few mistakes, I think that's all.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora finally reemerged from the north wing to join the others for lunch outside after her second outfit change of the day. Admittedly, the blindingly pink uniform wasn't as comfortable as the clothes she had back at home but it was still worlds better than the hospital gown resemblant garment she had the displeasure of wearing briefly before the change. It was symbolic in a way if she thought about it hard enough - the thick heaviness of the green fabric having been lifted off her shoulders and replaced with something much more breathable after she had admitted the truth of her issue to herself and everybody around her.

The lunchtime area was a square slab of pavement between the buildings and bordered with grass, with a few circular wooden benches and tables scattered around the space. It was refreshing to be outside in the cool spring breeze finally, as Adora had almost began suffocating in the condensed air in which her admission hung back in the north wing building. The sun was out and shining just like it was since the morning, but Adora still felt goosebumps of her now exposed legs beneath the hot pink skirt that fell just halfway down her pale thighs. They could have been from the light breeze that passed by every few minutes, keeping the temperature down, or her newfound truth which felt both freeing and shackling at the same time.

"Congratulations on your first step, princess," came the very same voice, smooth like honey with a raspy outline, the one which had

both blessed and grated on Adora's ears beforehand. Adora turned her head towards the table where Catra was sitting by herself instead of with the others, which Adora couldn't help but find quite fitting. There she sat, the smug look on her face irritating as anything. Adora's thoughts were soon interrupted by another voice, Lonnie's, she thought her name was, calling out from the table where all of the other inhabitants sat around.

"Don't listen to her. She's just bitter about the fish on her plate being the only kind she gets to eat," Lonnie called out towards them both with an eye roll, to which Catra responded with a low growl. Adora decided that was her chance to go and invitation to join the others, so brought her lunch tray and sat in the empty place between Lonnie and a small blonde boy whose name she vaguely remembered being Kyle. "So I'm assuming you're new to this whole thing, huh?" Lonnie asked Adora, facing her directly this time.

"I... yeah, I guess so," Adora nodded in response, absently picking around at her tray of food with her flimsy wooden fork. It was definitely surprising how comfortable the others seemed about the topic. Nobody batted an eye during her admission, the only real reaction was the clapping which Adora assumed was merely out of obligation. She realised these people have probably been living with this truth for quite a while now, unlike her, and that perhaps she was a little bit behind in that aspect. Despite that, she intended to keep her focus on the journey awaiting her ahead to her end destination of normalcy.

"It's cool to finally talk about it, right?" Lonnie spoke again around half a mouthful of something as Mermista scoffed at the display. Ignoring her, she continued. "Most of us don't get to talk to anyone else about it back home. We still have our friends, but you know how it is."

"Maybe you have the wrong friends," Catra replied across from her table where she sat alone, apparently perfectly content with that while still butting in on the others' conversations. Although her words did make Adora think. Wrong friends? Would so called

wrong friends only want what's best for someone? Adora thought maybe Catra knew more people like her who didn't mind that lifestyle, rather indulged in it on the contrary. Adora could hardly imagine it, she'd never met another homosexual in her life outside of the camp. Perhaps that was because they were all converted already.

The rest of the day was relaxingly uneventful, much to Adora's relief. She didn't think she would be capable to handle any other activities that day after just having being thrown in the deep end upon mere hours of her arrival. Later that evening, just before bed, Light Hope called Adora out of her room for a phone call. She stood in the cold hallway of the older woman's building in which she slept, holding the telephone to her ear as she absently twisted the coiled rubber cord around her fingers on her free hand. "Hello?"

"Adora, it's us," the sound of her mother's voice sounded through the phone, slightly warped and garbled through the weak line. "We know it's after lights out, but we just miss you so much."

Adora was grateful it was only a phone call, now free to roll her eyes at her mother's sentiment. She knew it was a childish and petty thing, but she still couldn't help but feel somewhat resentful towards her parents for being the reason she was sent away in the first place. However she knew she should think better of them, they were only trying to get her the support she needed. Her father's voice sounded before Adora could even think to respond. "We just wanted to know how our girl is doing."

"I'm doing okay," Adora sighed, leaning her back against the cool wall to which the telephone was attached. Her voice was quiet with the night, and lacking in emotion as well as volume. It was hard to feel strongly of anything after the day she'd had. "You were right. About the... the whole, y'know, queer thing. But it's alright, I'll be regular soon."

"Oh, that Light Hope was good then, huh?" Said her father.

“Mhm, and all the others,” Adora replied. “I’m already starting step two.”

“We’re so glad, and after all that money,” her father said before her mother quickly took over. “We can’t wait to see you up there at graduation, and to get you back home soon. Just remember that we love you, and we would do anything to give our Adora a normal life.”

“Yeah. Thanks,” Adora exhaled, her eyes drawn to the clock on the opposite wall, ticking away endlessly. It seemed the harder she stared, the slower the seconds would tick by. “I gotta go, I’ll see you both on Saturday.”

After an expectant Light Hope made sure the phone was finished up with and sent Adora back on her way to bed, she stepped back outside into the chillier nighttime air down the winding pavement back towards the girls building. There was a faint smell of smoke wafting in the air, the source of which revealed itself to Adora once she rounded the corner to see Catra standing there right outside the closed pink door, with a lit cigarette between her lips.

“Hey, princess,” Catra greeted in the same infuriating tone as always, having taken the cigarette between her index and middle fingers to free her mouth to speak. “Bedtime call with mommy and daddy?”

“What’s it to you?” Adora asked in response, slowing her pace to a stop despite herself. There was something so incredibly captivating about Catra’s presence as a whole which she couldn’t help but indulge herself in, no matter how much it annoyed her.

“It’s nothing to me,” Catra answered with a one shouldered shrug, flicking the ash off the tip of her cigarette before taking another drag. It was another few seconds of standing in tense silence before Catra offered the cigarette between her fingers out in front of her. “Want a hit, or are you too stuck up for that?”

“I don’t smoke.”

“I didn’t ask if you smoke.”

Adora didn’t answer right away. Catra wasn’t like anyone she’d ever met before, and she almost didn’t know how to act around her. Her responses were quick and her wit was sharp, a combination strong enough to almost knock Adora right off balance. Catra’s arm stayed out, keeping the offer open for a few seconds longer before she took another hit herself with a shrug. “Suit yourself. Better head to bed soon if you want your full eight hours.”

“Mermista was right about you. You are insufferable,” Adora said with a harsh exhale, not at all enjoying Catra’s self satisfied smirk at that, almost smug in the fact that Adora could hardly stand her. Before she let the other girl attempt to get another word in, Adora ducked her head and stepped around Catra to get to the bright pink door. She was a little bothered by the fact Catra didn’t make an effort to move out of her way in any capacity, but then again she expected no less. All she could do was toss and turn in her bed until sleep took her for the night.

The next morning, Adora was awoken at seven thirty as promised the previous afternoon. It wasn’t difficult to drag herself out of bed, eager as ever to start the day and continue her journey. She got changed and met up with the others and Light Hope in a separate wing following breakfast, which consisted of scrambled eggs that looked like clay and bacon so crispy it was almost fully black. She’d noticed another man made an appearance that day, a tall and rather flamboyant blonde man who took the group of boys to an area outdoors instead.

The room Adora stood in with the other three girls and Light Hope was perhaps the one that looked most perfectly sterile of them all. The building they were in contained a few different rooms, unlike the others, and the one they were currently confined to resembled something of a kitchen. Or rather a set created in one dusty unsaturated blue colour attempting to come across as a kitchen. The smell of cleaning chemicals lingering in the air was so strong Adora had pulled a face upon first entry, this time combined with

the strong smell of black coffee in Light Hope's mug. It was much colder than the outside too, the feeling only exaggerated by the absolute lack of colour in the place.

"Here at Eternian Amendments, we fully believe that training the mind through simulation to realign the correct orchestration of gender roles is most effective," Light Hope explained, opening one of the dull, almost fake looking cupboards to reveal a small collection of cleaning supplies which Adora assumed was the source of the acidic stench. "You will spend time in here for now and learn the basics of cleaning and operating in a kitchen environment, and I will of course moderate your progress. Step two will take place over multiple days and so involve different aspects of a woman's home life. You will need to partner up, so do so with the person on your left. Quickly girls, then come and grab your supplies."

It was just Adora's luck that she was paired with the last girl she wanted to be around for longer than five minutes at a time. It wasn't long before she was on her knees next to Catra in one corner of the kitchen room, both of them scrubbing at the floor in silence which had been intentionally muddied with footsteps from the outside. There was nothing but the sound of dense brushes against tile, the occasional water bucket dipping and Light Hope's heels clicking against the floor when she would stand behind them both with a clipboard in hand and observe them silently. It seemed as long as Adora refused to speak, Catra did too.

And so it remained for the next few days, they stayed working together in primarily silence. Apart from the occasional argument about who's doing what wrong, how they're meant to be and at what pace. Adora was actually somewhat surprised at Catra's willingness to properly get things done, although she knew it was on her for assuming things in the first place. She didn't want to say they were a good team considering they were practically working separately most of the time, but it still wasn't terrible. Apart from the frankly treacherous baby doll diaper changing course, something Adora was convinced Light Hope made them do purely for selfish amusement reasons, of course. That was the

closest and only time Adora was always one moment away from just giving up.

Sometimes while Adora was scrubbing floors or dishes in the same monotonous manner as ever, she wondered if the duties were truly working. If the cogs were turning subconsciously in her head and her expected roles as a woman was slowly becoming more sensical to her at every passing moment. She didn't feel too different than how she did when she started, and could only hope the dots were connecting in some deep corner of her brain. Somewhere that knew this was a glimpse into her future as somebody's wife, destined to keep the house and children under her care, despite how medieval it all still felt to her.

After what felt like months but was really only a few days in reality, the schedule finally switched up for the day. This time the two groups of residents within the rehabilitation camp were no longer segregated. Instead they sat on logs arranged in a circle around an unlit pile of wood sticks in the centre, outside on a breezy sunny afternoon. Light Hope was standing just behind them discussing something with that blonde man Adora had seen a few days ago, before they too sat down and Light Hope took the lead as always.

"Here today we will be discussing our roots. Now, I am aware that some of you have not yet discovered your root. Adora and Rogelio, isn't that right?" She asked. Rogelio nodded but made no effort to say anything else. She didn't speak much of anything at all, really, and so Light Hope continued. "Not to fear. How about we hear the roots of some of our other fellow residents firstly, hm?"

Adora sighed at the request, knowing she'd just be hearing the same things again. Lonnie had already explained to her all about "roots" since she'd missed that debrief on the first day, and was now familiar with the fact they were frankly just lousy excuses for the reasons of their presence at the camp. Within everything she thought and knew about homosexuality, it had never come across her that there was a specific event that could do that to a person.

Her own root was still unclear to her, and so she was so far stuck with just hearing about the others instead.

Even then, she supposed the others' made somewhat a bit of sense. Mostly, anyway. Like Catra - her "root" was that her stepmother was and always had been unmarried, meaning she took on both husband and wife roles within the household. With all they had been learning about correct gender roles in the past few days, Adora was beginning to understand better. So she sat, and listened to everyone going around the circle with their own experiences which could have very well been pulled out of their asses.

"And Adora? What about you, any progress?" Light Hope asked suddenly, snapping Adora out of her momentary reverie.

"Oh, no. I'm still looking for my root."

"Must be tough when you're such a priss," Catra chimed in under her breath, but the absolute lack of proximity between her and Adora allowed her to be heard. Still, after the past few days she was well used to Catra's unasked for comments and didn't bother with a response other than an eye roll.

"Okay, well, that's enough of that for now," Light Hope concluded, grabbing a few card boxes out of her bag and handing them out to every second person around the circle, each person looking as unenthused or even more so than the last. "Get into your pairs and we will revise what we have learned with our identity cards."

The sun was almost completely set by the time they were almost finished. Adora and Catra had found another log to sit on away from the others, and Adora was a few more cards away from completely losing her mind. Still, she was not one to give in so easily. So she reshuffled the card stack for what felt like the hundredth time and held the one on the top of the deck up to Catra. It was a pink card depicting a middle aged lady standing in a kitchen, rubber gloved and wearing an apron. "What is this?"

“It’s a woman,” Catra answered simply after having looked at the card for almost a full four seconds. Adora sighed but nodded, turning the card back to look at it. Just because Catra refused to do the assignment correctly didn’t mean she would too.

“And what else?”

“I don’t know.”

“Maybe a mother, too,” Adora supplied as she fixed the cards in her hands before handing them back over. “Women have roles. Haven’t you been listening to anything Light Hope said?”

“Whatever, it’s your turn,” Catra sighed as she took the deck off Adora, not even giving her a moment to react before pulling out a card of her own. It took Adora a few seconds to actually clock what she was looking at, scoffing and batting the pornographic image of some random woman out of Catra’s hand and so out of her sight. “You know, you really should be more prepared for unexpected temptation, princess.”

“How often do you expect I’ll be suddenly flashed a woman’s nude photograph?” Adora questioned sarcastically in response, brushing the not-there dirt from her skirt to as if to refresh herself after having seen such a thing. She didn’t comment on the silly nickname. She supposed she’d grown rather used to it from the sheer number of times it had been used by now, but even then it still sent a strange shiver down her spine.

“Out in the real world? More often than you’d think,” Catra shrugged as she dropped the deck of cards back into the small paper box they came in. Adora rolled her eyes with some small amount of amusement at that. Although she still thought Catra was ridiculous and infuriating and she drove her a little bit insane, she wasn’t completely unfunny.

Even the next day, their last day before family therapy, they had been sent to take on that godforsaken baby doll care segment. Out of everything, that component was dead last on Adora’s

ranked list. It was nonsensical and not at all productive to her. She knew next to nothing about caring for infants, but even she was sure that a plastic doll was practically nothing in comparison. It was also the one objective which required her to work the closest with Catra, and that often didn't end well. They were still worlds apart in differences and their competitiveness often resulted in minor arguments more often than not.

"First thing we do is pull these tabs out. Then you fold it over. I've used food colouring for you so you can see it better."

They stood shoulder by shoulder at the changing table, the horrific plastic doll laying motionless and mocking below them as they fought to properly put a diaper on the thing. Light Hope was droning on about tabs and positions and correct tightness but all Adora could hear was Catra's complaints in her ear.

"You're doing it all wrong," she said with a scoff, trying to pull on a different tab before Adora smacked her hand away.

"No, I'm not. If you would just let me do it, it would be fine," Adora countered, not fast enough to stop Catra again before she pulled on the wrong tab and the whole thing fell open, right as the doll dispelled the purple coloured liquid up and across, just far enough to catch Light Hope's pristine pastel purple shirt. Adora's mouth snapped shut at the sight of the woman suddenly freezing before calmly walking away.

Adora and Catra actually laughed together at that. It was a ridiculous situation of course, but it was... nice. It wasn't mocking or directed at either one of them, just a brief shared moment of amusement. And it was within that moment Adora realised maybe Catra wasn't as bad as herself and the others had painted her to be.

Saturday finally rolled around after the weekdays took their time having dragged out for what felt like much longer than what they were, but Adora still did not quite know peace. Weekends also meant family therapy, which she would have to first endure before enjoying the rest of her day freely. It wasn't that she was absolutely dreading the whole thing, merely uncomfortable after learning "family therapy" included everyone's families together in the same room near Light Hope's office with the woman in question. It was quite cramped to say the least, with Adora having a fine view of every resident and their parents while sat squashed in between her own. She locked eyes with Catra once or twice, who seemed less than displeased at the current situation. She noticed her stepmother, too, with a cold uncaring gaze directed at nobody else but her stepdaughter.

She just about zoned back in from one of the boys root stories again, Kyle, she believed his name was. Adora had heard about everybody's roots just about enough by now she could probably recite them word for word herself if she tried. However, the person snapping her back into focus with an impatient tone of voice was none other than Catra's stepmother. She was a cruel looking woman, Adora thought. All stiff posture and face set in a permanent scowl and a frankly quite harsh looking grip on Catra's shoulder that put even Adora on edge. Catra didn't look how she normally did in that careless, laidback and infuriatingly cocky manner that drove Adora insane. Instead her expression was blank, and she was almost a little paler than usual in her stepmother's presence. Quieter, too - she had yet to make a snarky comment for a single word that left Kyle's mouth.

"Well excuse me, but we're paying a lot of money to get these children fixed, not sit around and listen to stories all day," the woman said, her words just as sharp and cutting as her gaze was. Adora noticed her grip on Catra's shoulder growing physically tighter. "Catra, I hope you're getting a little more out of this program than that faggot over there."

"Miss Weaver, I hardly find that appropriate," Light Hope snapped, cutting her off quickly. The word Weaver had used obviously

created a tenser atmosphere in the room, and Adora could see her mother shifting slightly in her seat and clearing her throat uncomfortably. Almost as if she knew that was the case with her own precious daughter, too. It made Adora feel a little sick. Before Weaver could response, Kyle spoke again, nervous and blubbering as always.

"No, she's right. It was a dumb root. I'm never gonna know why I'm like this."

"I've heard just about enough of this," Weaver shook her head, standing up abruptly but still not removing her hand from Catra's shoulder. Adora felt so tense in her seat she was almost about to walk right over there and remove it herself. Most watched in either mildly scared or stunned silence as Weaver's head whipped downwards to glare sharply right at Catra's expressionless face. "When you get back home from here, you better have this gay thing out of your system, do you understand?"

"I understand," Catra replied. Adora thought she was trying to force her voice to sound even, but it just came across as strained and timid. It was so uncharacteristic for the girl she had come to familiarise herself with that it formed a deep pit in her stomach.

"You fuck up and it's no college, no car, no house," her voice was low and scathing. The threat was almost scornful, as if Weaver had not an issue delivering it in a room full of people. Anyone else was looking away awkwardly, however Adora kept her eyes trained on Catra, who now looked almost smaller where she sat. Weaver finally released her shoulder and picked up her handbag, walking towards the door with purpose in long, quick strides. "I'm not sitting in a room full of faggots any longer."

Catra stood up and left the room a short while after her. The door slammed, leaving the room with the rest of them to sit in silence for a few seconds while Weaver's words hung in the air. Adora was almost surprised nobody had intervened at some point, including herself. She couldn't even imagine how Catra had to have felt with that threat looming over her head for the rest of the program,

even as she sat straight and composed in her seat. Although that didn't stop Adora from noticing the slightly vacant look in her eyes.

"Adora."

The sound of Light Hope's voice suddenly cutting through the intensely thick atmosphere was enough to snap Adora out of her straying thoughts, blinking back into focus to look at the woman in front of her. Although she would be lying if she said her mind wasn't half occupied completely elsewhere.

"It's your turn to report out your root."

Adora let out a slow breath at that, nodding slightly as she cleared her throat. She had been spending the brief time she had until this moment to think over her situation for a viable, half believable excuse, even if she herself still did not quite believe it. However, something was always better than nothing, and she began explaining herself anyway.

"I think it might've been my parents," she started, the guilt already gnawing at her in the back of her head for throwing them under the bus like this. She ignored how she could feel their eyes on the back of her neck and continued. "We were always sort of this perfect family, you know? And then there was that one year, when... well my father was unemployed, and so my mother had to support us."

There was a silence after she spoke, and Light Hope was looking at her with an understanding that felt almost hollow as she nodded for her to elaborate. So Adora continued.

"Maybe it was seeing my mother doing my father's usual job," she said, wringing one hand in her lap as she spoke her perfectly orchestrated and perfected answer. "That I got the... y'know, the roles confused between them. Roles of men and women, I mean."

"Absolutely!" Light HopeI responded with a smile as she looked back at Adora, both of them clearly paying no attention to her

parent's reactions to that. While she did feel mildly guilty, Adora knew it would all blow over once she was out and better. “I can’t believe you didn’t mention this sooner. Your father was emasculated, your mother was domineering.”

“Well, not exactly - ”

“You wanted to emulate your mother,” Light Hope continued, cutting off Adora’s protests as she continued the elaboration for her. “You have no respect for men, because you have no respect for your father.”

“It’s really not like that.”

“Adora,” Light Hope smiled, clasping her hands together in front of her. “You have found your root. In order to start healing this festering wound, I would like you to write me a piece on how this has affected you. You’re a cheerleader, aren’t you? Try to use that, perhaps incorporate it in what you write.”

They were finished up shortly after. Or maybe it was a while, Adora couldn’t tell. She was unfocused when she wasn’t being directly spoken to or asked a question, and so her wind kept wandering to the previous scene with Catra and her stepmother. She thought it was a terrible thing, really, and found this itching need within herself to see how Catra was holding up. She hoped she wasn’t too upset, at the very least. Adora may not have liked her but she certainly didn’t hate her, and she didn’t think she deserved the kind of treatment she’d witnessed today. And from her very own stepmother of all people, too.

Some resident’s parents stuck around for a short while longer, but Adora’s had left soon after family therapy had concluded for the weekend. Adora found her legs taking her to the outdoors area of the camp and towards the small hill where she had watched Catra escaped away to earlier on. It wasn’t hard to find her on the downwards slope, smelling the smoke before she’d seen her, one knee propped up and the other leg out in front of her and a cigarette in between her fingers. Adora came up to stand in front

of Catra, make her aware of her presence, before sitting down next to her. She didn't miss the way Catra shifted when she did, a few millimetres away so their shoulders weren't touching.

"What am I, contagious?" She asked, her tone holding no malice unlike how it usually did to some extent when talking with Catra. Adora had a notebook in her lap and a pen tapping against her lower lip, opting for a staring contest with her hardly written cheer rather than drowning in the silence between them. Although it wasn't her who broke it.

"What are you doing?" Catra asked eventually, bringing the cigarette back up to sit between her lips. Adora looked up to face her to find Catra already looking at her. Head in her hand and a vaguely bored expression on her face, but still. Adora thought they could be friends if Catra became less annoying any time soon.

"The cheer I'm writing for Light Hope's assignment," Adora answered, rolling her eyes at Catra's scoff as she looked away again. "They're not meant to be super intellectual, alright? Cheers are supposed to be simple. Make people feel good."'"Cheers make girls do stupid cartwheels," Catra responded, taking another long drag from the cigarette before taking it between her fingers again. Adora was still looking at her, not too happy with her words but she was at least somewhat grateful a small flicker of Catra's spark was beginning to flicker back to life. Catra turned her head to look at Adora again. "You know what does make people feel good? Orgasms."

It was Adora's turn to roll her eyes at that as they both turned to look at the scenery ahead of them, mostly an expanse of grass with trees scattered around the place and some flowers colouring the view. It was another forever of silence between them, and Adora could feel the need to ask about the earlier scene between Catra and her stepmother growing ever stronger. She took a breath and put her pen down on the notebook in her lap. "Your stepmother didn't stay very long."

“Mm. I imagine it gets uncomfortable sitting that long with a stick up your ass,” Catra responded with somewhat of a bitter undertone.

“I’m sure she just wants to do what’s best for you,” Adora offered, although she was sure her tone was worlds behind the hopefulness of her words.

“I thought it was just an act, but you really are sweet as fucking pie, aren’t you?” Catra bit back, although Adora could tell by her voice she wasn’t as irritated as she had been at her in the past. Even if that was wrong, Catra still sighed in defeat, shrugging a shoulder as she took another drag and flicked the ash off her cigarette. “This is bullshit, Adora. The whole thing. It doesn’t work. You are who you are, the only trick is not getting caught.”

“So why are you here then?” Adora asked, although she assumed Catra likely didn’t have a choice in the matter, just like her and probably most of the others.

“I got caught,” Catra responded simply. She would turn her head every so often to look back at Adora, but would quickly turn to face forwards again. Almost as if she found the act of looking at her to be difficult. “And then my stepmom sent me here.”

Adora hummed in response, and they sat in silence once again. That was until Catra stubbed out her cigarette and stood to go. Adora found herself reaching up to grasp at her wrist as she did, surprising the both of them with the sudden action. The short few seconds they were in contact together seemed to pass by infinitely slowly, the feeling of Catra’s soft skin against her hand was enough to make her head swim for the short time it lasted. That was of course until Catra’s hand slipped out of her grasp and she stepped away.

“Careful, I could report you for that,” she said in a low, sarcastic tone before retreating back to one of the buildings and leaving Adora to sit by herself with nothing but her notebook and pen to accompany her. Catra’s absence left a strange hollow in her core,

although she assumed that was general loneliness. Still, she decided to stay and finish up the cheer in her notebook, the thought of which was beginning to wear on her patience. After all, Adora didn’t write the cheers. She only choreographed their routines to go along with them. Of course that didn’t stop her and she got it finished within an hour under the slowly setting sun and a bell ringing for dinner, her conversation with Catra lingering in her mind with every passing moment.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sorry if there are many mistakes, please let me know if there are (no beta whoops). Shadow Weaver's A+ parenting, everybody! Perhaps Catra's pov next chapter, who knows. Let me know what you think ;)

Breakout

Chapter Notes

> Back with a late update! No content warnings for this chapter I don't think, there is some fluff yay. Enjoy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora didn’t stop thinking about her interaction with Catra for the rest of the day. That, and just Catra, in general. She couldn’t help but feel as though her initial bitchiness was somewhat justified after seeing Weaver in person. In fact, that whole debacle left everyone a little lost for words and uncomfortable, enough at least for no shit to be given to or from her for the rest of the day. They did end up getting around to hearing Adora’s admittedly half-assed cheer at the end of the day, even if nobody was up for any more group activities for… well, for the rest of this damn programme, probably. Thankfully however, the mood lifted around dinner time so they weren’t going to bed wholly upset.

In the bathroom, Adora got ready for the night alongside the other girls who shared her dorm block as per usual. She felt her eyes wandering while she brushed her hair, to Catra who was cupping a handful of tap water to her mouth. It was definitely… a sight. Adora blinked her focus back to the mirror in front of her, feeling guilty for a number of reasons. First of all at her own lack of self control, but also for her thoughtless ogling of the girl who got completely chewed out and threatened by her mom in front of the whole group just hours prior. Then again, Catra herself didn’t seem too upset other than being extra scowl-y and somewhat quiet during dinner. She seemed used to it. Still, Adora didn’t want to be heartless.

She shook her thoughts off. She just needed to clear her head for the night, and it’d be a new day of progress tomorrow and another day closer to freedom.

Unfortunately, nothing could be that simple, and she eventually woke prematurely with an achingly dry throat. Amidst her journey in the dead of the night to retrieve a glass of water, there was a loud shuffle followed by a curse behind the kitchen's island counter. Adora quickly grabbed a stray fork from the cold marble and raised it in makeshift self-defence. She reluctantly took half a step forward before a head shot up from the other side of the counter, the sight of the person's arms immediately reaching out to try and hastily grab at her causing her to yelp.

Turns out, it wasn't just a head. It was Kyle's head. Followed by Rogelio. And now their frantic attempts at getting Adora to keep quiet, or even better, turn around and leave like she saw nothing, had been immediately foiled by her loud vocalisation. Undoubtedly notifying Light Hope, who came ushering into the room moments later. Kyle was the first and only of the three residents to desperately start rattling off excuses for their situation, but even then it wasn't looking too good. Light Hope simply stood with the same stony, expressionless features as she took the scene in before excusing Adora and leading the boys to her office.

Apparently the commotion had alerted the others, as Adora soon found herself standing with the rest of them outside of Light Hope's office in an attempt to listen in on their punishment. She wrung her hands, just barely making out the sound of a stern, no-nonsense voice, but not the contents of what she was saying. But it couldn't be good, they all knew that. Catra turned to shoot her a questioning look, and all she could do was shrug helplessly in response. It wasn't her fault - she didn't make anyone do anything illegal, but she still couldn't help the guilt gnawing at her insides for being the declarer of their crimes.

The next morning at breakfast, the table looked up as the door to the main building opened. Kyle walked down the steps, rather clumsily from the large case in his hands, and Adora's heart dropped. Something about seeing somebody actually being removed from the programme hit her like a ton of bricks, and her fingers tightened around her fork. He gave an awkward wave goodbye to the table, earning some back, before going off on his

way to whatever vehicle was waiting for him in the car park. He didn't look too bummed which was… good, Adora guessed. She hoped he'd be alright.

The rest of the day passed relatively normally, which Adora was grateful for after all the excitement recently. She still saw Rogelio around, so she assumed he was just on some kind of probationary period for now. The day's activities didn't stray from the usual household maintenance role-plays, but she didn't mind, not with Catra as her partner to had seemed to have livened up significantly compared to the previous day.

At some point, Light Hope brought them into the projection room to show them some old slideshow of demonstrations of a happy, functioning couple in normal society. Try as she might, Adora couldn't pay attention to her with the lights low and Light Hope's voice droning on about how this "could be her." That was, of course, until she felt the ghost of Catra's fingertips against her arm. Neither dared look at the other, but Adora's focus was laser sharp for the remainder of the hour.

They got the rest of their tasks done for the day while talking and laughing together more than usual. It was fun, in a way, even when that had initially seemed like an impossible concept. The day practically flew by, and soon enough Adora and Catra were on their last task in the kitchen, scrubbing and polishing the dishes and silverware.

"Do you miss your friends back home?" Adora asked as she handed another glass off to Catra to polish and put away. She tried not to think about how closely they were stood together, even though she could feel their shoulders pressed together.

"I don't really have anyone back home," Catra answered honestly and smoothly, like the fact didn't bother her. Adora wasn't too sure about that, but she let it go. "What about you?"

"Yeah, I miss my friends," Adora said, and she did. She missed her squad - Glimmer, Bow, all of them. She hadn't realised how much

she actually talked to them or how active they were in her life before they were gone. She scrubbed another glass. “It kinda really sucks here.”

Catra hummed in agreement, taking the glass to polish with the pink rag in her hand. She glanced at Adora with a half-smirk. “Could be worse though, right?”

Adora met her gaze and smiled in return. “Could be worse.”

That night, when Adora entered the bathroom with toothpaste and toothbrush in hand, she was shocked to say the least at the sight that greeted her. All of her roommates dressed and ready to go to who knows where, including Catra. In fact, Catra arguably looked the best of all of them, wearing a deep maroon shirt with the buttons halfway undone, a leather jacket and black pants and shoes. Adora’s mouth opened and closed for a second before she was able to form a question. “What’s going on? It’s almost lights out.”

Mermista, Lonnie and Catra all snapped their heads towards her at the same time once she asked, like they weren’t expecting her. Had they deliberately planned this around her? Could she really even blame them? Maybe she had really destroyed their trust in her after that whole situation with Kyle and Rogelio.

“We’re sneaking out,” Catra replied simply and quietly as she put her eyeliner down and turned to face Adora in the doorway. The contour of the black on her waterlines against the two tones of her eyes was pretty in a way Adora never understood before. “Get dressed.”

“But what if Light Hope -”

“Fuck Light Hope.”

Adora was momentarily stunned into silence, and also maybe a little intrigued. Wait, what was she thinking? “No, there’s only four weeks left. No way am I getting thrown out now.”

"Adora, there's no way she could possibly find out about this," Catra replied, which was probably not true but coming out of *her* mouth it sounded like the furthest thing from a lie. Adora really needed to get a hold of herself here, but Catra had already walked closer and leaned against the doorframe next to her. "Besides, we haven't had fun in forever. And you definitely look like you could really use some fun."

Adora tried to keep her composure, she usually didn't crumble so easily. Or at all. "What if we get caught?"

"We're not gonna get caught," Catra replied in a tone that sounded mocking to her own, but Adora couldn't find it in herself to care. She was too drawn in by those black-framed eyes and infuriatingly cocky smirk, like Catra already knew she convinced her. She could feel the others' eyes on her already, and finally relented with a weak sigh and nod. Catra's smirk only grew. "Great, we're leaving in ten."

Those next ten minutes were spent hastily as Adora struggled to put together an acceptable "sneaking out" outfit and get herself ready to go out'. The makeup she usually wore was negligible at best, but she found herself trying a little harder in the mirror that night. Of course until Catra let her know it was time to go, and so the four of them slipped out of their dorm block and into the cool breeze of the night.

Adora decided it was best not to ask questions as Mermista led them out, ducking past the window's of Light Hope's room and half-running across the grass and dry dirt to the car park out at the front of the facility. There were only two vehicles there Adora could see - Light Hope's sleek, silvery blue Cadillac and further down, a large van with its engine running which seemed to be the target.

They successfully made their way down to the rather loud vehicle, Mermista taking the lead in dragging open the sliding door to the back of the van. She seemed to be a repeat offender, Adora thought. They clambered in, one by one, and the first thing Adora

noticed in the darkness of the space was that the two other guys left in the boys' group that had not been caught 'fraternising'. Adora understood why Rogelio didn't tag along, and she felt a little bad.

Adora managed to land a seat close enough to Catra to be pressed right up against her. She tried to put a little distance between them, she really did, but there was so much random junk and equipment in the pitch black darkness of the van that there wasn't much hope to begin with. Lonnie and Mermista settled across from them, which was when one of the two people in the front turned back to them.

"Hi!" One woman greeted with a friendly smile. She was sitting in the passenger seat with her arm extended across the back of the driver's seat. She focused on Adora, apparently recognising her inexperience at whatever the hell this endeavour was. "I'm Spinnerella, that's Netossa. Glad to have you with us!"

"Glad to… be here," Adora returned with an uneasy smile before Spinnerella reached for a small bag and dumped it in her lap. Adora opened it up to reveal the contents inside - several fake identification cards. She looked up with confusion at Spinnerella, who waved her off simply.

"You won't find a perfect match, but one will do," she started. Adora hesitantly shifted around the bag to find a picture which could vaguely resemble her, while Netossa spoke up. She looked more no-nonsense than the other woman, but not to Light Hope's degree. Her features were kind. "They're just for entry, alright? We trust you enough not to get completely wasted, you're all smarter than that."

Adora caught Catra rolling her eyes at that part, even in the dark they were still pretty bright. Adora wasn't sure if she was rolling her eyes at the protective nature of Netossa's words, or if she really was coming on this venture with full intentions to get blackout drunk. Adora wouldn't exactly blame her, but like Netossa said, that was probably an incredibly stupid idea. She was pretty

sure there was no excuse for waking up hungover, still drunk the next morning bright and early at Eternian Amendments that would get by Light Hope easily. Or at all, for that matter. That was fine by Adora, she was never a big drinker at parties back home anyway.

"Spinnerella and Netossa are ex-ex-gays," Mermista explained to Adora, brushing a hand through her hair.

"From Eternian Amendments?" Adora asked, and Netossa shook her head before answering while still driving down the long, winding road that led them away from the establishment.

"Not quite, but someplace similar," she responded, her fingers tightening and loosening around the wheel. Spinnerella put a hand on her shoulder. "But we have had a little… er, feud, with Light Hope going for a while now."

"We're just trying to provide you all with a balanced perspective," Spinnerella continued gently, still turned to face the group in the back of the van. "To see that there are options! In the end it's up to you whether you want to choose to live a…"

"Lie," Netossa cut in sharply, earning a half hearted glare from her… partner? Adora assumed so. Spinnerella turned to face the group again with a small smile.

"Whether you want to be who you are or keep it hidden is really more what we're about."

But Adora was sure there wasn't meant to be a choice in the first place. That's why she was put in Eternian Amendments in the first place, right? To eliminate the choice, and give her a clear path. The right path. But the way Spinnerella was speaking about it made it seem like that wasn't wholly true, and maybe she was right. It was hard to come to a clear conclusion about such a big revelation in her life when two opposite sentiments were constantly thrown around in her head to fight for dominance of belief.

Once they arrived at the mysterious location, they were quickly bustled out of the back of the van with well wishes from Spinnerella and Netossa. Adora followed the others blindly to some dark backdoor to the building. She could see fluorescent lights coming from the front of it, presumably where the name of the place hung in neon colours. Once they stepped inside, Adora's senses were immediately assaulted with flashing lights, a sea of bodies pressed up against each other, the smell of smoke and booze. Her hand subconsciously went to play with the small silver cross charm dangling from around her neck, her head whipping to Catra who was already producing a cigarette from who knows where.

"You didn't tell me we were going to a *gay bar* ," Adora said in a hushed, conspiratorial tone as she looked around, as if their surroundings were a shameful secret not to be heard about by their peers.

"Well duh, where else would we go?" Catra replied with a smirk as she took in Adora's reaction, taking the cigarette between her lips before turning towards the bar. "C'mon, I'll get you a drink."

"I told you, I don't drink," Adora huffed, but Catra was already gone. Adora was left to fend for herself in this unforgiving queer jungle of sorts. After a solid four seconds of standing still like a newborn fawn on shaky legs, Adora found it in herself to follow the path which Catra had gone in the direction in.

She tried to take in her surroundings as much as possible as she wound between people dancing, drinking, making out or whatever else. In short, it was overwhelming. But no matter how hard she dug, Adora couldn't find the visceral feeling of disgust or distaste that she was half expecting to still be buried in some dark corner of herself. Just… normality. It felt real.

She eventually reached the bar, leaning back against the counter as Catra soon approached her with two brown glass bottles of beer, handing one off to Adora, her protests falling on deaf ears. Adora finally agreed to reluctantly take it, holding it at the neck

and partly away from her. She could practically feel the cross necklace sitting snugly against her chest glaring disapprovingly at the beverage. It was stupid. She tucked it behind her shirt anyway.

Catra lit her cigarette, smoke dancing tantalizingly out from between her lips. The two stood in silence for a few beats. Adora shrugged off her red jacket, the atmosphere of bodies close to bodies causing her to swelter slightly. Catra took a swig of her beer before speaking.

"You don't have to look so worked up, you know," she commented, leaning casually back against the bar alongside Adora as she shot her a sidelong glance. "Just be yourself."

Adora looked back at her heterochromatic eyes, shiny and brighter under the fluorescent lighting. She appreciated the granted freedom, although Adora couldn't even begin to be herself here of all places, when she didn't even know who *herself* was meant to be.

After looking into Catra's eyes wordlessly for probably a little too long, her mouth opened to speak before they were suddenly interrupted. Adora turned to look at the newcomer, whose arrival she hadn't even noticed until the girl in question cleared her throat.

She was tall, buff, and had long, white hair tied back in a ponytail. She was the exact picture of the female sports figures Adora usually admired before. The girl only looked at Adora, as if Catra wasn't standing there at all before she spoke.

"Hey blondie," she greeted, her voice lower than Adora expected with a gravelly quality. "Want to dance?"

Adora blinked in genuine shock for a few moments, subtly glancing behind her to make sure this mysterious, admittedly attractive girl was really talking to *her* . After confirming, it took

Adora another couple of seconds to process the question and quickly sputter out a response.

“Oh- uh, no, sorry, I, uh- I don’t dance,” she managed to get the words out quickly. The girl didn’t look too bothered, shrugging a shoulder before taking a step back towards the dance floor, alone.

“That’s alright. Just thought I’d ask.”

The moment she stepped away, Catra delivered a sharp smack to Adora’s shoulder, making her yelp in shock. She didn’t even get a chance to question her before Catra started speaking, already taking her beer off of her and pushing her forward.

“Too good for one dance?” She goaded, still nudging Adora forward despite her protests. “You can’t dance with a girl for a second? Go on already.”

Adora sighed heavily and eventually stopped resisting, shooting one last desperate glance over her shoulder. Catra simply shooed her away, and so Adora made her way over to the girl again. The girl didn’t even look surprised, almost as if she’d expected her to come running back after that missed opportunity. They didn’t say anything, the girl taking the lead in placing her hands around Adora’s waist, holding her closer and closer as they danced to the sensual music. Adora felt her heart racing in her chest as her arms naturally wound their way around the girl’s strong shoulders.

This didn’t feel like how it felt dancing with her boyfriend at prom. It could’ve been that they just fit together easier, or the smell of the girl’s perfume, or the feel of her hands on her waist. It was better. But there was still something preventing Adora’s wholehearted satisfaction.She was surprised at herself for enjoying it at all, really. A mix of emotions were swirling around her core, but she still couldn’t find it in herself to be ashamed. Guilty, maybe, but not ashamed. She let the iron grip of her thoughts go for a moment as she concentrated on the dance.

That was of course until she glanced around the dance floor and spotted Catra dancing with Mermista. They were probably as close as Adora was with this girl, but it still rubbed her the wrong way. She could see the way Catra's head was tucked in against Mermista's shoulder as they swayed together. Her position was practically mirroring Adora's, but for some reason that didn't make her feel any better.

The upcoming feeling of whatever that was suddenly became too much for Adora. It was stupid and nonsensical, but she had to leave. She abruptly stepped out of the girl's arms, not hearing her protests as she quickly walked out a different door to some back alley where the trash bins were kept.

Her chest felt tight still, so she paced a few steps before deciding to sit down on a short wall opposite the bar. One of her legs was tapping furiously as she tried to get the image of Catra so close with somebody else out of her mind. It wasn't long before her failed attempts at focus were interrupted by the door slamming open after her, as Catra emerged too. She looked around for a second before spotting Adora, who braced herself as she was approached.

"Adora, what the hell?" Catra started, standing in front of Adora as their eyes met. "What was that?"

"What was what?"

"Don't pretend you don't know what I mean," Catra furrowed her brow as she looked down at Adora with a fiery intensity she hadn't seen before. "Why the fuck did you storm out like that just now?"

"I don't know, seeing you like that with Mermista was weird," Adora answered uncomfortably, but it wasn't a total lie.

"Come on Adora, you know I don't like Mermista like that," Catra gritted.

“Oh? And which way is that, clothed?” Adora shot back. She was unsure why this was working her up so much, but the whole situation was beginning to tick her off.

“We weren’t doing anything,” Catra huffed, crossing her arms across her chest defensively.

“It doesn’t matter.”

“Why are you freaking out?”

“It’s none of my business.Do what you want.”

“Oh, you want me to do what I want?” Catra asked, her gaze still burning intensely into Adora’s. Adora suddenly shot up from her seat on the wall, growing angrier as she got closer to Catra.

“I could care less,” she spat.

“What I *really* want?” Catra continued, getting closer to Adora as they looked at each other angrily.

Adora couldn’t help it, she was really boiling over now. “Screw you.”

And then, soft lips against her own. Adora’s eyes were still open, her whole body frozen in shock. But Catra didn’t stop, or pull away, instead cupping her cheek and drawing her even closer. Adora felt her eyes fluttering closed against her will, the frustration and annoyance in her chest suddenly fizzling out into butterflies and warmth which spread quickly to the rest of her body. Her head was empty as she just allowed the moment to play out, even leaning into the warmth of Catra’s touch at one point before it was as if suddenly as if she regained consciousness and pulled away. Their eyes met again, this time with a noticeable lack of hostility, replaced with something gentler.

“I’m not supposed to like you,” Adora said. Her voice was barely louder than the cool night breeze around them. She wasn’t sure who she was trying to convince with her words.

“But?” Catra prodded, her hand moving up to hold Adora’s arm to keep her close.

“I wanna do that again,” Adora admitted, desperately pushing away the guilt that clawed at her heart for even considering the want. But Catra didn’t react to her words the same way her inner conscience did. She was sincere and understanding, rather than doubtful and afraid and abashed. Catra slowly pulled her in again. It wasn’t like the first time. This time Adora could predict what was coming, and even then she didn’t have the willpower to make herself pull back before it was too late and she continued to allow this girl to pull her apart and put her back together.

Their lips pressed together again in a synchronized dance, this time a little more intense and somehow more desperate than the first kiss. Catra was close enough to allow Adora to take in the scent of her cologne and smoke still clinging to her skin and clothes, which usually would have bothered Adora but she couldn’t find it in herself to care at that moment. Catra’s arms snaked around her waist and it suddenly fell into place what was missing when Adora was dancing with that girl before. Adora herself took minimal initiative and drew Catra slightly closer, her arms wrapping around her in exchange as Catra kissed her two, three, four times more. She wasn’t sure how long it was before they finally, reluctantly pulled apart for air.

Sneaking back into Eternian Amendments somehow felt more incriminating than sneaking out, Adora thought. Maybe it was the fact she’d mostly undone everything she’d tried to learn there, and felt some nagging guilt at her lack of remorse for the fact. The group bid Spinnerella and Netossa goodbye for the night, crouching under Light Hope’s window to make it back to their dormitory building.

With racing thoughts, Adora changed into her nightclothes and climbed into her horrifically pink bed. Right before her eyes fell shut for the final time that night, a sudden weight draped across her body. She turned her head in confusion only to be half an inch from Catra's face for a millisecond before Catra planted a quick kiss on her lips, hopping off the bed again and returning to her own. Adora was given no reaction time, instead just smiling like an idiot to herself as she rolled over in bed, planting a pillow on her face.

Her head was still thrumming from the events of the night. The blood rushing through her veins was getting to her head, making her feel strangely elated.

There was a smaller, muted part of her screaming disgrace and dishonour. She knew now this was why she was here. She knew she had a boyfriend waiting for her back home. She knew she was actively regressing instead of growing out of an obscure phase, and while it frightened her to her core, she was starting to get a clearer view of the other side. Maybe she could still make the choice hers, she just had to get out of here first.

Chapter End Notes

> Oh wow they kissed, surely nothing can go wrong at all from this point onwards...! Leave a kudos and comment if you enjoyed please thanks bye ;)

Caught

Chapter Notes

> still in time for pride month! gay times ensue! sad times ensue! Content warnings for descriptions of a panic attack, and (mostly non explicit) smut. Enjoy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had a sobering morning to wake up to the next day. She was the last out of bed for once, taking her time getting dressed and ready for the day before she had to join the others for breakfast and then group. She could hear Light Hope shuffling around the room for the daily morning inspection, but it didn't matter since Adora had already moved into the bathroom. She left after a few minutes anyway. Adora was able to cloud her own mind enough with the plans for the upcoming day until she literally had to face herself in the mirror to wash her face and brush her teeth.

She looked into her own eyes as the refreshing burn of cold water washed over the skin of her face and ran down her arms beneath her sleeves. She was almost expecting to see a different pair of eyes looking back at hers. She knew she wasn't any different than the person she was last week, physically at least, but the events of the previous night made it seem as though she had thoroughly metamorphosed and left not a trace of recognisability behind.

She kissed Catra. No, Catra kissed her. That didn't sound any better despite Adora's hopes. The thought of it, the memory of soft lips against hers, it all left a nauseating amalgamation of intense anxiety and something reluctantly softer. She'd never felt more conflicted in her life, so torn between definitions and feelings of right and wrong. Adora was scared, but only because she *liked* it. She not only liked it, she found herself unable to keep her mind off of Catra herself. She was an intense magnetism that Adora couldn't help but to allow herself to be drawn into. She

hated to admit but the uncertainty was somewhat intriguing to her. Catra's alluring nature excited Adora more than her boyfriend ever did. Catra left her *wanting*.

The cross necklace she still wore hung heavy around her neck, weighing her down some. She never felt particularly close with God or the church or anything like that despite her parents bringing her bright and early each Sunday, but some part of her still felt a little bad. Maybe because of the way her parents looked at life through a Christian issued lens. She knew it was inevitable that they would never accept any outcome of her time at Eternian Amendments except a thorough cleanse and straightening out, but lately Adora has been worried she'd only been straying further and further from that expectation no matter how hard she tried.

She didn't want to lose her family. She wasn't unhappy with her life as it was before she arrived here. She was just… restlessly longing for something different. She just wished that that could coincide with this new part of herself which was slowly unfurling and blossoming. The only stable commodity she knew she could always hold onto was her friends, but giving up her family for them and her own happiness was a difficult sacrifice.

Adora washed the sleep from her eyes, moving her hands away from her face. Once she blinked her eyes open again, her gaze caught Catra's through the reflection of the mirror which made her jump slightly. Adora didn't hear her approaching, or making herself comfortable leaned against the doorframe of the bathroom.

"Hey Adora," Catra greeted, her lips catching a small smirk as Adora patted her face dry with a towel. "You missed breakfast."

"Yeah," Adora replied, turning around to lean back against the sink and face Catra properly now. "Aren't you meant to be at group right now?"

"Aren't *you*?" Catra shot back, but neither seemed to be too bothered in actually making it there. "I didn't think you were the

type to test your limits with Light Hope like that."

"Yeah, well. Screw Light Hope, right?" Adora replied, relaying Catra's words right back to her. Her response seemed to greatly amuse Catra as Adora relished in the sound of her squeaking laughter. It was distinct and pretty and Adora thought she wouldn't mind listening to it all day and into the night.

"I'm a bad influence on you, princess," Catra chuckled with a smirk as she slowly approached Adora by the sink. "You're good after last night? Not on the brink of mental collapse?"

"Not yet," Adora responded. She couldn't help the smile that tugged at the corners of her mouth as Catra drew closer.They just stood like that for a few moments, taking each other in in a comfortable silence. Adora was sure Catra was about to move in even closer before the door to the dormitory building suddenly flew open.

"Girls?" Light Hope's stern voice rang out and echoed around the bathroom walls, and the two girls jumped back from each other reflexively. "You were to be at group by now. I urge you to hurry yourselves up, there is a very serious matter at hand to be discussed immediately."

Once they finally arrived at the group room, Adora took her seat between Catra and Lonnie. Nobody looked particularly pleased to be there, some even worried. Light Hope shut the door after them with a sigh, standing in front of the group in silence for a few moments before retrieving something from her pocket and holding it up for display. It was a small business card, colorful and with the name of the very same gay bar they'd snuck off to last night written in bright, bold lettering.

"I have come across this very disturbing artifact this morning while I was inspecting your dormitory," Light Hope started, her expression steeled as she shot her firm glare between every last person sitting nervously around in the semicircular arrangement of the chairs. Adora felt the hairs on the back of her neck standing

up, lightly running her fingers over the newly arised goosebumps on her arm. She knew she was probably the least guilty out of anyone who had snuck out last night, but she still felt like some kind of ringleader in this situation. Still, she knew it wouldn't be pretty even if she got the long end of the stick with Light Hope's reprimands.

"I would like to know exactly *who* has been sneaking around in the dead of night," Light Hope continued, her hands coming together in front of her. After a few beats of silence from the group, she spoke again. "I can assure anyone who informs me of their misbehaving last night will receive a lesser punishment rather than leaving it to fester before I inevitably find out."

For some reason, Adora didn't quite believe that. She shot a quick glance at Catra next to her who had her expression cooled into something neutral and somewhat unreadable.

"I want *names*. I need to know who was involved," Light Hope said finally, before her stare landed on Catra and her eyes narrowed dangerously. "Fine then. Catra, what do you have to say for yourself?"

"What? What are you asking *me* for?" Catra scoffed in response, leaning back in her seat. Adora didn't know how she could constantly exude such aloofness even in situations like this. If it was her, Adora would've already crumbled and been on her ass kicked out the door by now.

"Because this was found under *your* bed," Light Hope responded, holding up the business card again in front of Catra's face this time. Adora watched as her expression turned from indifferent to an almost innocent confusion that had even Adora believing she was as faultless as she looked for a half second.

"But… I didn't sneak out," Catra said, her voice laced with wholly believable sincerity.

"But you know who did," Light Hope prodded.

"No, I don't," Catra trailed off, playing with her nails for a moment before looking up at Light Hope through her lashes. Adora had to bite down hard on the inside of her cheek to hold back a laugh now. "But… I did realise something about myself last night. I think I was too scared to admit it until now."

Adora's intrigued gaze met Catra's eyes for a brief moment. The corner of Catra's mouth quirked up in a barely-there smirk.

"I have a *big* crush," she declared. Light Hope's eyebrows shot up at the admission. Adora watched as Catra turned to face the boys' side of where they were sitting as if searching for the perfect victim. From where Adora was sitting she couldn't see the look in Catra's eyes, but she knew it must have been harsh enough to keep the chosen target silently pinned to his seat. "On Rogelio."

Adora slowly released a shaky exhale in favor of a laugh. Rogelio looked frightened and the others looked at varying levels of disbelief.

"Oh," Light Hope straightened up with a mildly bewildered expression.

"It was the first time I ever felt something for a guy and it just – it really proved to me that treatment's working." Catra's voice carried an underlining of something akin to emotion so convincingly that Adora herself may have believed the fib if she'd never interacted with Catra before.

Adora couldn't really distinguish Light Hope's expression but the woman nodded, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder briefly before addressing the group. "Wonderful. Let this show you all what true determination can yield. I want you all to observe Catra's strength and how she worked her way through this five step programme."

"And by the way, I am very disappointed in the rest of you," Light Hope quickly continued, flicking the business card still between her fingers as her narrowed eyes darted between the group. "And

I have scheduled a meeting with each of your parents. If you refuse to listen to me, then perhaps you'll listen to them."

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Adora and Catra sat side by side on the steps outside of Light Hope's office, listening to the sound of one of the boys crying and pleading with his parents with bated breath. Adora's stomach was coiled up in a tight nest and she could hear the blood rushing through her ears and feel every pounding of her heart through her chest.

She wasn't exactly sure what was to come of the meeting, which was probably what scared her the most. She wrung her hands in her lap until they were white from the loss of blood, biting on the inside of her cheek. Occasionally she glanced at Catra next to her who she would've expected to be in a worse state than herself, if only her mother showed up. But her car had been missing from the car park the whole time and any chance of her arrival didn't seem too promising. But Catra didn't seem to be too mad about it. Adora sure as hell wasn't.

Adora felt a strange longing for the feel of Catra's hand in her own in some desperate search for comfort before one of them had had a heart attack from stress. But even in the highly intense atmosphere, Catra's fingers were subtly grazing back and forth over Adora's leg and even that was better than nothing.

Minutes or hours could've passed by in overwhelming silence, Adora didn't notice any time passing. Not until the door to the office swung open and the boy walked out, his parents following closely behind him with concrete expressions. The sounds of footsteps moving from the seating area inside moved to the office, and before she knew it Light Hope was calling Adora's name. With a final breath she stood to enter – when Catra suddenly turned to her.

"Hey, you're not gonna tell your parents, right?" She asked, her eyes searching Adora's. Adora looked at her silently in return for a

few moments before answering. “Of course not.”

Adora entered Light Hope’s office with all of the courage she could muster. The scene was similar enough to her arrival, the only difference now being her parents seated on either side of Light Hope rather than her. She hadn’t seen them in weeks and she couldn’t truthfully say that these circumstances for reuniting were too enjoyable. While that was true she still felt some hurt about the utter lack of greeting upon her arrival.

Her parents already seemed familiar enough with the situation since Light Hope didn’t need to say a word of introduction or explanation before Adora’s father set off.

“Now, honey,” he cleared his throat, shifting in his wooden seat. “Your mom and I both know that you didn’t have anything to do with that… field trip to that, uh place.” He looked to his right across Light Hope at Adora’s mother, who sternly nodded at him before he looked back at Adora. “But, you have to know that if you had gone… you would be on your own.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Adora asked as her eyes darted between her parents, uselessly pulling at the collar of her dress as if it was denying her oxygen. Was it getting hot in here?

“Well you can’t come home,” her mother snapped. “We cannot allow you to live such a lifestyle under our roof.” She sighed. “So, Adora, if *that* is what you choose – you’re choosing to cut us out of your life.”

Adora’s hands never left her own tight grip and she could now taste the coppery flavour of blood in her mouth from biting down on her cheek too hard. She practically felt like her whole world was coming crumbling down around her, it might as well have been. She thought back to last night, her lips against Catra’s and how she had all too thoroughly enjoyed it, all while her family and home and life as she knew it were dangling above a fire pit ready to drop at any second and *why was the air getting thicker to breathe?*

“Well great,” Adora’s father exhaled, sitting up straighter and clasping his hands together. “Now, what would you like to tell us?”

“Just that you’ve got nothing to worry about,” Adora responded automatically. Her voice didn’t sound like her own, but then again maybe her hearing was impaired from the deafening sound of blood rushing in her ears. “I’ve been missing home a lot. My friends. And boyfriend, I can't wait to see him again.”

“Oh, Adora, sweetheart, that’s wonderful,” her mother chirped up with a hand on her heart and a relieved smile on her face. “Now, you just keep up the good work, and we’ll be back to see you graduate.”

“You’ll be home before you know it,” her father added. Adora’s blurry gaze looked up and her parents were suddenly bent down by her sides, kissing her cheeks and bidding their loving goodbyes.

Adora could hardly even feel herself in motion as she arose from the chair and left Light Hope’s office without a word. Her thoughts were too clouded to distinguish from one another and she only felt the prima urge to breathe, but even as she stepped outside into the sun her lungs wouldn’t expand. Out of shame or protectiveness, she didn’t know, her legs carried her away from the office and around the building where the others weren’t sitting, not even sparing a glance at Catra.

Once she was satisfied she was alone, her back hit the wall of one of the buildings of the camp and she slid down to the group, uselessly grabbing at her chest as tears fully blurred her vision although had yet to fall. She felt her hand shaking uncontrollably, ready to just pass out or die or however god had planned for her to collapse against this building when she heard her voice, the sound muffled but growing louder.

“...’dora?”

“Adora?”

“Adora, where are y-”

The voice only stopped when Adora felt a hand grabbing her own. As she blinked, the tears finally rolled down her cheeks, somewhat clearing her vision for her eyes to land on Catra’s pretty ones as she crouched down in front of her.

“Adora, breathe,” the soothing, melodic sound of Catra’s voice rang clearer in Adora’s ears now. Catra offered her hand which Adora quickly gripped like a lifeline as she continuously gasped for air. “You’re okay, Adora. I’ve got you, baby, just breathe. Copy me, okay?”

Adora nodded and focused all of her energy in mimicking Catra’s breathing patterns, exaggerated, slow inhaling and exhaling. After what felt like hours Adora finally found her breath again but her energy was thoroughly depleted. While she was glad to stably breathe again, that also meant her thoughts had somewhat cleared up and she soon found herself crying heaving sobs into Catra’s shoulder while the other girl held her through it, patiently petting her hair and whispering sweet comforts all the while.Adora would’ve marvelled more at her sudden sweetness if she wasn’t so distraught in that moment, but she still appreciated the gesture.

The rest of the afternoon passed by in a blur. While it was nice to be in their own little bubble for a while, eventually Adora and Catra had to rejoin the group for an evening “”party.” Really, they just stood around the outdoor eating area with each other, Light Hope and a sad looking store-bought sheet cake. Catra made an effort to stand with Rogelio to really drive her point home although she looked thoroughly bored. Adora was exhausted from recovering from earlier on so she sat with a few of the others but didn’t engage much.

Eventually the two caught one another’s eye, and Catra shot a quick wink at her over her shoulder while Light Hope was preoccupied. Adora smiled despite herself, looking down at her lap as she picked at a thread on her dress.

Late that night when they were all in their beds, Adora was laying wide awake and staring at the pink ceiling in the dark. She heard Catra shuffle out of bed and head towards the bathroom, only to diverge at the last second and crouch down between the wall and the side of Adora's bed. Adora sat up but Catra pushed her back down with a palm on her forehead. Adora smiled at that and turned to lay on her side to face the other girl.

"What are you doing?" Adora whispered.

"Am I not allowed to talk to you now, princess?" Catra returned just as quietly and Adora's smile only grew. "I just… about earlier. Are you… okay?"

"I'm better," Adora replied, her expression evening out a little bit. It wasn't untrue. She didn't know if she was okay, but she was certainly better.

"Okay," Catra exhaled, biting her lip as her eyes searched Adora's face. "Do you wanna talk about it or something?"

"Not really, no."

"Okay."

They were silent for a moment before the corner of Adora's lips quirked upwards slightly. "Goodnight, Catra."

"Night," Catra answered with a small smirk, throwing a cursory glance at the other beds before leaning up to press a quick kiss against Adora's lips before she stood. "Princess."

Some days later both the boys and girls were lined up and sat on a bench outdoors while Light Hope addressed them about their final task. Despite the number of weeks of tedious tasks and lectures and meetings, the programme was slowly coming to a close before Adora even really had a chance to realise that. She had probably spent too much time in Catra's company, too much time enjoying her friendship to notice the time passing. Maybe

she would have blamed that on her lack of progress if she still cared so much about making it.

Her conversation with her parents had been marinating in her head for days since it happened. After some extreme hesitation and a lot of convincing from Catra, she was starting to lean into a more 'one step at a time' approach. After all, it was a little difficult to let herself succumb to her anxieties with Catra kissing her near every chance she could and her reassurances. Even if it was pure bullshit, any word from Catra's lips resonated more profoundly with Adora than any gospel ever did.

"Listen up now, everyone," Light Hope said, bringing her hands together. "You will all be graded in each category, and those of you who pass will move on to step five. Simulated romantical lifestyle.. Those of you who fail will be sent home. Girls with me."

They spent the day doing a combination of everything they'd been doing in the last weeks. More cleaning, dresses, essays - *My Root and How it Prevented Me from Heterosexual Loving* - and cleaning some more. Adora wasn't feeling too miserable about it herself, she was enjoying her day with Catra far too much to allow the boredom to catch up with her. By the time both groups were back on the bench for evaluation, Adora was giddy and out of breath from being chased by Catra all the way back down there.

"Well then, let's get started, shall we?" Light Hope said, holding her clipboard up to her nose before bringing it down again. "In all my years at Eternian Amendments, never have I had such a determined group of individuals." She didn't sound too enthused but then again, did she ever?

"I am passing all but one of you. Rogelio?" She stated, the boy in question not seeming too perturbed at his failed status. "Pack your bags. Now, there's cake in the kitchen. You'll want to rest up for the simulation."

Light Hope walked away after that. There were some pitying glances but Rogelio simply stood and left. Catra snorted a laugh

resulting in a quick elbow to the side from Adora who was only thankful that somehow they both managed to make it under Light Hope's radar long enough to keep their places.

"Well. Congratulations, liars," Catra declared once Light Hope was far away enough to be out of earshot. She stood up, brushing herself off and grabbing Adora's hand to haul her up.

"And just where do you think you're going?" Mermista asked, her tone monotone as always but laced with some interest as she looked at the pair of them from where her head rested in her hand. Catra was already leading Adora away although she dropped her hand in favour of gently pushing her along by the shoulder. Adora certainly wasn't fighting it.

"You didn't hear?" Catra responded over her shoulder with a shit-eating grin. "There's cake in the kitchen."

Adora vaguely heard some complaint from Lonnie behind them but her focus was whisked away once they were out of sight and Catra's hand slipped *right* down to her lower back. Adora gasped, unable to keep the blood from rushing to her now scarlet face.

"You wanted to get some cake?" Adora asked, her tone mildly flustered as Catra continued to lead her down the path between the buildings.

"Adora," Catra chuckled in reply and she didn't need to say more. Despite that, they eventually did make it to the kitchen with the others.

They both silently agreed they probably shouldn't do anything more than kissing while the sun was still up and there was a risk of anyone walking in on them. Adora's stomach fluttered at the thought – *not* of someone walking in on them – but the idea of *more than kissing*. That's what that was, right? Catra wanted something with her that was more than kissing. The thought made Adora giddy with excitement.

Neither of them dared to let their eyes linger for too long for the rest of the evening, at least not until a few hours after dinner when everyone was well and truly asleep and then some time after that.

Adora's heart began pounding the moment she heard the springs from Catra's mattress to quietly creak as she shifted out of it and into Adora's. While they weren't exactly swimming in space, it was big enough once Adora shifted over some.

"Hi," Adora whispered, her mind otherwise blank. It was only now hitting her how inexperienced she truly was. Was it obvious? Or was Catra expecting something? She probably didn't want her to make it awkward. Oh, god, she was definitely making it awkward.

"Hey, dummy," Catra replied with a lazy smile as she shifted to get comfortable, throwing an arm over Adora's waist and moving closer so their faces were mere inches apart. "What's got you so wound up?"

"I don't know," Adora murmured. "I don't know what to do."

"That's okay," Catra reassured her, brushing a strand of Adora's hair away that had fallen over her eyes. "We don't have to do anything, you know."

"I know," Adora hummed in response. The butterflies returned to her stomach as her voice was reduced to a quiet whisper. "But I want to. If you do."

"Oh, Adora," Catra breathed, moving closer until their lips were just grazing and they were sharing the air between them. "You have no idea.'

Their lips met finally. It was so different than all of the previous times they had kissed, of course it was – it was damn near impossible to ignore the newfound undercurrent of a frightening combination of lust and hunger that Adora was unfamiliar with. The thrill of Catra's practiced lips against her own never dulled since the first time, it was still the most beautiful sensation Adora

had ever experienced. Catra's hand tightened around Adora's waist and she nipped her lower lip. The simultaneous actions caused Adora to gasp in pleasant surprise, granting access for Catra's tongue to swipe against her own between her parted lips.

Soon enough, Catra's kisses led down Adora's jaw and then her neck after that. She lightly sucked the skin there, and Adora could only hope at that point that she wouldn't leave an obvious mark despite every bone in her body wanting the complete opposite. Catra took her time kissing every inch of Adora's skin above her collar, or maybe Adora was just feeling the time go by in slow motion.

She hardly even noticed Catra practically manhandling her into a position on her back in the middle of the bed until her lips left her skin and Adora looked up to see Catra hovering above her. Adora's hands came up to caress her cheeks, feeling the soft freckled skin under her fingers. She could spend hours like this, just observing Catra's face, counting her freckles and getting utterly lost in her eyes.

"You've done this before?" Catra asked, still conscious to keep her voice low enough not to wake the others. Adora assumed Catra was just asking out of politeness considering she could feel herself quite literally blushing like a virgin, and nothing too crazy had even happened yet. She shook her head no anyway.

"Okay," Catra exhaled, leaning down to kiss both her warm cheeks. "Okay. I'm gonna take care of you, okay?"

"Okay."

And take care of her she did. The two spent the next while wrapped up in one another's embrace, biting lips to keep quiet, giggling sometimes. It was different to how Adora ever imagined herself having sex with someone. She didn't feel repulsed or hesitant like she thought she would with her boyfriend all those months ago. She damn near saw stars while Catra was under the sheets, between her thighs – she'd never seen anything more

beautiful in her life than when her eyes locked on Catra crawled back up her body with that hazy look in her eyes and chin glistening.

After some insisting from Adora and Catra assuring that she was fine, the two just stayed cuddled up together in Adora's bed for as long as they could before Catra had to go back for the night. They were both still dressed in their pink issued sleepwear, much to their annoyance but it was just a precaution.

"I've never felt that way before," Adora whispered against Catra's shoulder, who hummed in response. She didn't even really mean that in a sexual aspect, more so the pure exhilarating joy she felt for the first time in a while. Something that really got her blood pumping and left her in a sort of high. "Well, maybe except…"

"Except for what?" Catra chuckled softly from where her chin rested atop Adora's head, her body shaking them both slightly with her laughter. From disbelief or mirth, Adora couldn't tell.

"Don't laugh at me," she huffed softly. Catra stopped her laughter with a breath and some effort.

"I'd never laugh at you, princess."
"Mhm."

"Are you ever gonna tell me then?"

"Except for when I was cheerleading," Adora admitted, her fingers trailing along Catra's side as she awaited her response.

"Yeah?" Catra responded. She pulled back to look at Adora, her eyebrows raised but there wasn't a trace of real judgement she could see in her expression.

"I'm serious," Adora murmured in response. "It sounds stupid, but I really love it. It's one of the things that's really kept me happy. It's exhilarating."

“I would love to see you cheer,” Catra hummed softly, kissing the corner of Adora’s mouth who giggled quietly.

“Do not make fun of me.”

“No, I’m not,” Catra smiled with some amusement as well, before caressing Adora’s cheek and looking into her eyes with something more intimate. “Did you ever think maybe I’m just jealous that you love something?”

Adora smiled at that but didn’t prod. It was late enough already. They kissed goodnight and Catra eventually slithered back into her own bed so as to not get caught by dawn. Adora couldn’t stop smiling until she fell asleep late into the night.

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“Adora, get out of bed.”

Adora groggily blinked awake at the sudden stern command. She must’ve slept in. However, once she sat up she saw none of her roommates present. nJust Light Hope standing at the front of her bed, glaring daggers into her. Adora’s heart dropped to her ass, the tiredness evaporating from her body instantly.

“I can’t believe you did this,” Light Hope continued before Adora could even move. “You were supposed to be the role model. Get up right now.”

“What did I do?” Adora asked as she swallowed down her nerves. She hoped that she’d been somehow caught for anything else other than what she was thinking.

“Get dressed this minute, and meet me in my office.”

Adora was sick with nerves by the time she’d gotten dressed and ready. On the short walk from the dorm building to Light Hope’s office, she didn’t see even one other person. She didn’t care about anyone’s whereabouts, none but Catra’s.

She entered the office and found herself in a very similar situation she was in just a few days ago, sitting facing Light Hope alone. Except this time, rather than a baseless accusation she was facing, she was *caught*.

"You of course understand what your little endeavor has cost you, Adora," Light Hope's sharp voice cut right through the tense atmosphere like a hot knife through butter. She was regarding Adora with such unbridled disdain that Adora felt the simultaneous need to run or to fight right back. But what had she to fight for anymore? This already was her second chance. "You will be removed from the programme and the premises at once."

"...I understand."

"And of course your parents have made it very clear that you are no longer welcome home any more," Light Hope continued. "Since you are eighteen years old, you will simply be left to your own devices. Now I suggest you go pack your bags."

Adora opened her mouth to respond but was immediately silenced by Light Hope's glare growing even sharper than before. She quickly rose from her seat and headed for the door, her mind a swirling, blundering hurricane of thoughts with the only coherent one being the need to pack up.

She almost tripped stepping outside of the office building seeing Catra walking towards the door, only she was not alone. Her stepmother had made a reappearance, an uncomfortable iron grip on Catra's shoulder that made Adora's blood boil. Their eyes just barely met for a second but Catra's gaze snapped away when the hand squeezed her a little harder.

Adora rushed back to the dorm building to pack her stuff as quickly as she could so she could meet Catra once she left the office. She didn't want to get too hopeful, but how could she not? This was the perfect opportunity for them both to escape, wasn't it? Sure, Adora had no idea where they would go, but after the

things Catra had said to her last night, she didn't care. She felt genuinely happy as long as they were together.

She was just coming back up to the office when the door swung open and Catra's stepmother walked out, closely followed by Catra and finally Light Hope, who shut the door behind them. "Then it's settled. Catra will carry out the simulation and continue on for graduation. Adora, best be on your way." She didn't linger a moment longer before walking away with her clipboard clutched tightly against her chest.

Adora didn't think it would be possible to feel her heart physically tearing itself in half but here she was. Her suitcase felt a hundred pounds heavier in her hand as she frantically searched Catra's face for something, anything – but all she got were desperate, whispered apologies before she followed after Light Hope.

Adora was left standing on the landing of the office building with nothing but a case of her belongings and a freshly broken heart. She didn't even get a chance to tear up before Catra's stepmother spoke.

"It is for the best, child," she said scathingly, narrowing her eyes at Adora before making her way back to the carpark.
With a deep suffering inhale, Adora made her way down the path towards the exit of the establishment. Tears stained her cheeks, and rain followed not long after. She walked.

Chapter End Notes

Not beta read, mistakes likely. Hope you enjoyed this one :)
There may be a 6th chapter for an epilogue, still undecided.
But for now, any thoughts?

Graduation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“We’ve lost Adora.”

Catra expected it. The moment she opened her eyes to see Light Hope at the foot of her bed, wordlessly nodding to the door. The moment she locked eyes with Lonnie standing a few feet behind her, arms crossed and a smug smirk that made Catra feel borderline violent.

Some part of her thought Light Hope would offer Adora some punishment in exchange for letting her stay, but she was more enraged than Catra had ever seen her. Enough so that she didn’t even consider bargaining, after all she barely scraped by with it the last time.

“She clearly wasn’t strong enough.” Light Hope’s words made her jaw clench but she was too deep in her own shit for retribution – she’d likely be out within the next hour anyway. Catra kept her eyes trained on her unforgiving glare, intimidating as it was, but she wouldn’t look into Weaver’s eyes if she could help it. “But you have been granted a chance to save yourself.”

Wait… what?
“Your stepmother has been kind enough to offer a quid pro quo of sorts in order to keep you in this programme and allow you to graduate along with your peers,” Light Hope continued, and Catra was now severely aware of the thick envelope clipped to the clipboard on her desk in front of her. “You have been granted a renewed opportunity to lead a normal life.”

“There is no choice,” Weaver cut in, the harshness in her tone sending a shiver right down Catra’s spine. She could feel her stepmother’s eyes burning into her even as she shifted her gaze

to the floor. “You came here to graduate, and that is *exactly* what you’re going to do. Do you understand me?”

Catra felt weightless with every step she took towards the door, following after Weaver with Light Hope behind her. She had half a mind to run, but it would be useless with her stepmother’s car that would be hot on her heels in a minute. She only had one objective now; graduation. Useless as she felt, it was the only open door by this point. Graduate quickly so she could somehow find Adora, somehow make it up to her.

She could hardly even meet Adora’s eyes once they got outside and she was already there. All she needed was five minutes alone with her for an explanation, apology, *something* – but Light Hope was already saying something about her exit and Weaver wasn’t moving. The despair across Adora’s face was practically nauseating considering she was feeling this way because of Catra. She didn’t think she could ever feel like this big of a coward.

She’d never felt how she did for Adora for anyone or anything else in her life before. She was the unexpected light at this hellish camp. Her growing care for the other girl was almost a little terrifying if she didn’t *like* her so damn much. Catra didn’t even know if like was the right word any more.

When Adora looked at her with those eyes and she could practically see her unraveling in front of her, she may as well have driven a blunt blade through Catra’s chest. She could’ve melded into the ground right then and there if Light Hope didn’t whip around while she was walking away beckoning towards the others who were waiting inside for group. Desperate, useless apologies left Catra’s lips under her breath before she walked past Adora. Her sharp nails dug roughly into her palms as she willed the tears from her eyes, leaving her. Leaving Adora behind.

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Adora was extremely disgruntled to say the least. Her wheelless suitcase was growing heavier in her hands by the minute, and the

rain wasn't exactly a great motivator. She felt like she was in the midst of one of the romcoms her friends would make her watch that made her roll her eyes – crying, drenched, walking along the side of the road in the middle of nowhere in the pouring rain for god knows how long. She was pretty sure that the car which drove past her a while back that deliberately sped through a puddle next to her was Catra's stepmother.

And she was still dolled up in that same horrific pink get up from this morning.

She was about two more stumbles away from giving up and trying her hand at hitchhiking before a van pulled up beside her. She grimaced, expecting an older man but was presently surprised when the window rolled down and it was those two women who snuck them out all those nights ago, Spinnerella and Netossa.

"Adora, is that you?" Spinnerella called out. "Hold on, come on over and get in here, sweetheart."

The older woman stepped out of the car from the passenger seat, ushering Adora to clamber into the middle front seat between Netossa, who was at the wheel, and a newly reentered Spinnerella.

"Christ, what happened to you?" Netossa asked as she started the van again, continuing down the road. She clicked her tongue disapprovingly before Adora even answered. "I swear, I'm gonna kill that Light Hope when I see her again! What'd I say, this happens every damn year!"

"Oh Adora, are you alright?" Spinnerella asked, her tone carrying a much softer and more patient tone than her wife's. Adora wiped her face with her wet hands, sniffling slightly when she realised she was still crying. "Aw, hey. It's gonna be okay. I know it might be hard to see right now, but you know there's nothing wrong with you. You're not the problem here, okay?"

"No, it's not about that," Adora replied shakily, shrugging off her near dripping cardigan to drop at her feet. Even she herself was surprised it wasn't about that. She definitely came a long wave since her arrival, that was for sure. She couldn't even expand, she wasn't sure she wanted to, before both wives responded with an embarrassingly knowing chorus of *ahhhhs*.

"Oh honey. That first, tragic lesbian heartbreak is always the hardest hitting," Netossa shook her head with pursed lips as she drove, one arm leaning against the window. "Who was it? Catra, right? I called it, Spinny, that's ten bucks."

"*No*," Adora sputtered, her cheeks heating up. These people had only seen her and Catra interact for, what, an hour total in the back of a dark van? This was humiliating. "I mean, yes. It was Catra. But this is not a *tragic lesbian heartbreak*."

"It's okay, Adora, it happens to the best of us," Spinnerella replied after rolling her eyes at Netossa's unwavering competitiveness. She patted Adora's shoulder sympathetically. "Don't worry. You can come back with us for as long as you need, we're well used to taking in stragglers from that queer penitentiary. The more the merrier."

"You are coming with us, right?" Netossa asked, casting a side glance at Adora. "Family coming?"

Adora shook her head.

"We'll help you get settled until you decide what you want to do," Spinnerella smiled warmly, which did make Adora feel a little better. Sopping wet in a van squished between two veteran lesbians wasn't exactly how she planned her departure from Eternian Amendments, but she wasn't complaining.

"I don't know what I can do," Adora admitted with a small sniffle, her breathing evening out again and the tears beginning to dry. "I don't know *how* to be a lesbian. What they wear, where they live, y'know."

"Adora, we can't help you with that," Netossa replied. Adora deflated a little before she continued. "There's not just one way to *be* a lesbian."

"You just have to keep being who you are," Spinnerella finished.

Adora sighed and leaned back in her seat, getting comfortable for the rest of the ride which was spent mostly in silence apart from Britney Spears blaring loudly from the radio. At least now she had some time to figure something out.

Sitting back in group after the events of the day was jarring to say the least. Catra felt like her body was open and bleeding out and everyone was carrying on business as usual. She was alone with her thoughts, practically dissociating in the silence before Light Hope cleared her throat and began speaking over them.

"Today we will complete the fifth and final step before graduation. Simulated romantic lifestyle," she introduced, gesturing around the room. "We will conduct a realistic scenario and have you paired off with one of the girls or boys. Perhaps it would seem similar to a high school prom – consider it practice."

Light Hope tried her best to split them off into twos, but after all of the mishaps throughout the programme they were left with an uneven number of two boys and three girls. Once they moved the benches out of the way and Light Hope began playing terrible music, Catra happily sat out for the first round of whatever-the-fuck while the others got into position for some kind of slow dancing.

After all of the shit she'd almost forgotten about Lonnie before their eyes met across the room, and suddenly Catra was only interested in one thing. Lonnie was spun away out of Catra's sight after that so she was left to quietly seethe alone. Except not really alone, never truly alone here, as she could practically feel Light Hope's eyes on her constantly. She didn't know what the hell she was expecting any more, she was hardly fucking any other girls out here in the broad daylight.

As much as she pretended she didn't have to, Catra was eventually called up to swap places with Mermista. She lightly brushed shoulders with her as they walked past one another and she sighed as she threw her arms over the guy's neck and his hesitant hands met her waist. She didn't look at him, she didn't want to – if anything this stupid camp only reinforced her queerness more – and wondered what Adora was doing now, where she was. Hopefully safe.

Thinking about Adora quickly transformed into just feeling like a complete asshole, so she huffed and looked around the room again. She was almost tempted to start something with Lonnie here and now, but she'd wait. She had a lot to speak with her about, after all.

"Catra, focus please," Light Hope's stern voice came from a few feet away. Catra rolled her eyes and cursed under her breath before she finally looked at the guy whose arms she was unfortunately in. She didn't even know his name, she didn't care to. His eyes were blue like Adora's, except Adora's were a prettier shade like the ocean on a cloudy day or a luscious lavender cotton. The boy was unextraordinary at best in comparison, and he only made Catra miss her more. Thankfully he didn't seem to be very interested himself.

The "simulation" lasted a few more songs and partner swapping before they were finally freed. Graduation was only two days away but it couldn't possibly seem farther away. Thankfully Light Hope let them off for the night with an early dinner, and Catra finally caught up to Lonnie once they got back to the dorm room building. Right before she could step inside, Catra sped up so she could yank her back by the shoulder.

"*What the fuck* –?" Lonnie sputtered, but Catra was already dragging her by the wrist around to the windowless side of the building where nobody could see them. She slammed her back against the wall with a huff.

"You wanna tell me exactly why the fuck you pulled that little trick this morning?"

Lonnie scoffed, shoving Catra's arm off of her own. "Missing your girlfriend already? It hasn't even been a day."

"Don't fucking joke around with me, Lonnie," Catra hissed in response, her eyes narrowing at the other girl. "Were you really that bored? Are you serious, you know how soon we graduate?"

"Oh I'm serious, alright," Lonnie shook her head, trying to slip into the open air but Catra only backed her further into the wall. "You're so full of shit, you know that? Acting like I started this."

"Started *what*?"

"Your little girlfriend," Lonnie spat, jabbing a finger against Catra's chest for emphasis. "Did the exact same thing a few weeks back, did she not? You remember the night Kyle and Rogelio got caught? 'Cause they sure as hell didn't manage that themselves."

"You – what?" Catra replied. She did recall that night ages ago when Kyle was booted the very next morning. "What the hell are you talking about?"

"And you and I both know Light Hope only failed Rogelio because she was holding a grudge from back then," Lonnie continued. "Because of her."

"The fuck does this have to do with anything? Unless you're…" Catra trailed off, her narrowed eyes searching Lonnie's, who visibly deflated somewhat now. Catra sighed heavily and dragged a hand down her face, stepping back in disbelief. "Jesus Christ."

"I'd say we're even," Lonnie said, crossing her arms now as she leaned back against the wall behind her. "But, y'know. It *was* one for two."

They stood in silence for a few moments after that, the only sound around them being the crickets. Catra certainly wasn't

feeling any kind of apologetic, but her burning anger has quelled somewhat, at least towards Lonnie.

"Look, I know it was messed up," Lonnie admitted as she dug through her pockets and pulled out two cigarettes, one went between her lips and the other was offered to Catra as a sort of peace offering. "I was mad. I still am. This place is not fucking fun. *Especially* not by yourself. You probably get that now, huh?"

Catra sighed and took the cigarette, taking and striking a match that Lonnie held out with it. "Guess so."

"Alright then. If we're cool or whatever, fine, but I'm not smoking with you," Lonnie grumbled, turning to walk around to sit at the back of the building instead now that Catra had moved back.

Catra exhaled deeply and rubbed a hand across her eyes, taking a long drag from the cigarette as she stood alone now in the night. It was eerily similar to a night all those weeks ago, except that night Adora was still there getting adorably worked up while Catra goaded her about calling her parents. It was odd, Catra didn't realise how fully bleak this place was until moments like this, alone, or when Weaver came along, or when Light Hope was lecturing her. She missed Adora's company now more than she ever thought she could.

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Netossa and Spinnerella's house was tucked away in a small gated neighbourhood down a long, winding cobblestone road off the original road they were taking. The neighbourhood houses were near identical to one another and reminded Adora of her own home – or what was her own home. Nevertheless, she was happy to step inside to the smell and warmth of timeliness and love rather than the cold, suffocating air that lingered around Eternian Amendments.

Netossa and Spinnerella followed closely behind her and shut the door. Netossa dropped Adora's soaked suitcase on the floor with a

huff and brushed her hands off. “You got pretty far with that thing, kid. You do weights or something?”

“No,” Adora answered on autopilot, feeling a little awkward and out of place as she stood out of the way so the wives could lead her somewhere further inside. She slipped off her shoes by her bag, weary not to track wet mud and rain into the home.

“No? Maybe you should try it out,” Netossa replied, clapping a hand against Adora’s shoulder gently before lightly pushing her down the hallway into the living room. There was a smell of warm food wafting through the room coming from the kitchen, which Adora found odd until a familiar head popped around the doorway.

“*Kyle*?”

“Adora!”

Kyle hurried out from the kitchen into the living room, clad in a deeply saturated rainbow-coloured apron, and threw his arms around Adora unexpectedly – who was half anticipating a deserved smack. She stood stock-still in confusion before Kyle released her, still holding on to her arms with a beaming smile.
“Thank you so much for saving me from that place!”
“What are you doing here?” Adora asked, the mild confusion still present but relief crept into her tone.

“I live here! Well, at least until I find a way to make it on my own,” Kyle responded, looking over Adora’s shoulder at the two women watching them. Adora looked back to the women who were smiling fondly at them, Netossa’s arm wrapped around her wife’s shoulders.

Dinner that night was better than anything Adora’s eaten in the past few weeks. She was surprised Kyle could be such a competent chef. Sitting around the table, Adora also noticed two unfamiliar faces who joined them. She assumed they were

escapees from last year, which was both comforting and worrying simultaneously.

She liked to think that she'd find herself going somewhere within a few weeks, maybe months. But it was nice to have the safety net that Netossa and Spinnerella had cast, just in case.

Late that night, Adora brought her suitcase up to her own bedroom, small, but her own. Yet another huge upgrade but a difficult difference to adjust to either way. Still, she found herself in Kyle's bedroom that evening just to talk to someone, and it turned out he was a surprisingly good listener. He was sitting in his bed while Adora leaned back against the open windowsill, grateful for the cool breeze filtering into the room.

"This is way better than that place," Kyle said. "We all get our own rooms, and the curfew is midnight. Only thing is we have to share bathrooms. Not at the same time, of course."

"Of course," Adora replied. The weight of her day was finally settling on her shoulders now that she had a moment to breathe, but the clarity came with the pain in her heart with every beat.

"It's gonna be okay," Kyle said, the usual timidity piercing his tone slightly.

"No, it won't," Adora retorted, but her voice was weak and came out as a whisper. "She was meant to leave with me, and she didn't."

"Woah, slow down," Kyle said, straightening up suddenly. "Who?"

"Catra."

"I knew it! She was into you from the start," Kyle grinned like he'd won a bet or something, before clearing his throat.

"Well then why didn't she come with me?" Adora asked dejectedly.

“Maybe she was scared?”

“...Like I’m not?”

Kyle sighed, scratching the back of his head. “Believe me. You’re better off here.”

There was a few seconds of silence between them before Adora suddenly realised something. “Hey, what about Rogelio?”

“Uh, he’s gone back to his parents’ place,” Kyle laughed nervously, looking off to an empty corner of the room. “We’re figuring it out.”

Adora smiled at that. At least someone out of this whole endeavour wasn’t totally miserable. “I hope it works out for you guys, seriously.”

“Thanks, Adora,” Kyle smiled broadly in response. “Actually… we were gonna meet up at that gay bar that’s not too far from here, I heard Netossa and Spinnerella took you guys there one of the nights. You should come with us, you know, celebrate your new freedom.”

“I – uh… Yeah, sure. Why not,” Adora shrugged, smiling slightly at Kyle’s enthusiastic reaction. She didn’t exactly feel in the mood for any parties or clubbing any time soon, but maybe it could do her some good. She couldn’t sit around crying forever. Maybe just tonight.

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“We could dance if you want?”

Kyle’s suggestion might as well have fallen on deaf ears. Adora was standing leaned against the bar looking out at the dance floor the same way she and Catra did the night they snuck out. Kyle had just taken a break to grab him and Rogelio a drink when he approached Adora.

Adora could see the same white haired girl who called her Blondie and asked her to dance. Some other chick was tucked in her shoulder the same way Adora was, but she truly couldn't care less. All it did was make her feel more bitter about her current girl-in-arm situation.

"I think I'm gonna go get some fresh air," Adora said after a while, straightening up and leaving the bar through the same door she stormed out that night, and sitting on that same short wall. Except this time it wasn't Catra following after her, just Kyle.

He sat next to her and they sat in silence for a while. Adora sighed as the silence dragged on, willing the tears to leave her eyes so she didn't have to deal with the embarrassment.

"I miss her," Adora said simply.

"She's scared and probably making the wrong choice," Kyle replied, scratching absently at his knees. "But it's her wrong choice to make, y'know? Sometimes you have to walk away."

Silence.

"I… might have an idea," Adora said eventually.

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Catra felt ridiculous on a good day at this place, but this just crossed a line.

Light Hope had provided them "formal" wear for their graduation morning, but the poofed out pink dresses the girls were all currently decked out in were anything but that. Maybe she meant formal in the same way a six year old is for her birthday party.

"How's it feel to be straight?" Mermista asked sarcastically as she entered the bathroom where Lonnie and Catra were getting ready. She was in the same dress, forcibly deflated with a hair tie that crumpled the hem so weirdly that Catra thought she'd probably prefer the inconvenient flare. "Feeling reborn yet?"

“Most definitely,” Lonnie chirped sardonically in response. Catra didn’t even answer. Ever since her eyes opened that morning her mind was constantly creating and redoing mental plans for her escape after graduation. How the hell she’d escape her stepmother, and the even unlikelier scenario of tracking down Adora. All in all… it wasn’t looking too good.

“Girls,” Light Hope’s stern voice booming from the outside door made her jump out of her skin, and snapped her focus back into the present when she accidentally yanked a hair out of her head. “Ready to go?”

A begrudging response followed and Light Hope waited right at the open door, inspecting their appearances closely as they marched one after the other out of the building and towards the outdoor graduation ceremony. It was in a different area they hadn’t been to before during the program, the patch of land on the other side of the parking area. It was by the road surrounded by trees, and a shallow but wide enough slow-moving river.

The set up for the graduation reminded Catra of that of a church mass that her stepmom would drag her to when she was younger, back before Catra started resisting so hard that she gave up on taking her altogether. There were benches on the grass set up like pews and everyone’s parents, including her own, sitting patiently awaiting their child’s mighty reformation to be all tied up with a neat little bow and packaged home with them.

She followed the group down the centre of the benches to the very front row, getting as comfortable as she could in her massively poofed up dress. Light Hope followed after them and stood at the top with a podium and microphone, looking far too pleased with herself for what this was.

“Good afternoon everybody, and you are all very welcome to this special day with our graduating class of Eternian Amendments,” she greeted, and received a pleased applause from their audience. It took Catra one glance around the benches to see that each

parent shared the same sadistic glee of successfully brainwashing their children into heterosexuality, or so they thought at least.

It sent an uncomfortable shiver down her spine, and that was without even looking at her own stepmother. She could only imagine the satisfaction etched into her expression at her little "win."

It was hard not to zone out to the sound of Light Hope's voice droning on after so many weeks of enduring just that. There were some words Catra picked up on, mostly things like "proud" and "accomplishment" and "good life," amongst other niceties. That was, until something caught her attention.

It caught everyone's attention, really. It was hard not to notice something as large and chaotic as a van coming down the road, before divulging off the tarmac and speeding up through the river. The river which happened to be on the opposite side of the graduates, but the water splash certainly didn't miss the parents sitting right by it.

There were outraged shrieks and a confused stutter from Light Hope as Catra and the others gaped at the scene. The van, which was slowly looking more and more familiar, slowed down slightly so that the back door slid open and who appeared behind it was none other than Adora.

Catra couldn't form a coherent thought fast enough it seemed, and Adora herself looked utterly shocked at the drenched state of the parents. Catra was already standing by the time Adora had snapped out of it and began yelling her name, holding her hand out as the van kept moving. Slower, but still moving. And that was all she needed.

Catra was incredibly grateful at that moment that the stupid dress she was wearing didn't come with a pair of matching heels, mindlessly legging it for the van. She wasn't thinking straight, Light Hope was yelling her name through the microphone and Weaver yelled threats of no college, no car, no life. She didn't

care. She didn’t care, because her senses were locked on Adora, sweet Adora who didn’t stop reaching for her hand until she reached the van and hopped in and she was laughing and crying in her arms all at once.

“Jesus, fuck,” Catra gasped for air, sitting up straight again and cupping Adora’s beaming face to make sure she was really there. “I can’t believe you.”

“I can’t believe that actually worked,” Adora laughed. Spinerella in the front had a death grip on the door handle and her wife’s arm, who was still cheering and whooping and she turned back onto the road. “Oh my gosh, are you okay? That was really – I, your stepmom –”

Catra didn’t hesitate this time to kiss her, and Adora didn’t wait to reciprocate it. The kiss felt like an oasis in the desert, the calm after the storm. It was messy and their teeth clashed slightly from how hard they were both smiling, but neither cared. Adora’s arms snaked their way around Catra’s shoulders as she pulled her in closer, surprising Catra in the best possible way.

They were obviously careful not to get too rowdy in the back of the van while Netossa and Spinnerella were right there, but that didn’t mean they separated by any means. There were a million things running through Catra’s mind and a million things she wanted to say to Adora, but they sat quietly in each other’s arms as they were driven to who knows where.

Catra was glad to be gone, and glad to no longer have to see her life through the little lens that was constantly being held to her face. Suddenly things didn’t seem so cosmically out of reach, like she could actually have a chance in this world, with Adora, of course.

Adora sat on her knees right in front of her, in a slightly awkward position but neither of them cared to move from the other’s hold. It didn’t feel like the pressure of the very air was choking her, and she felt more at ease than she had in a very long time. Each

shaky exhale felt like expelling the poison she’d been breathing these last few weeks, finally taking in lungfuls of fresh, free air. She pressed a kiss against Catra’s temple, holding her closely as they drove farther and farther away. Back to Netossa and Spinnerella’s house, and then somewhere after that. She didn’t know, and it didn’t matter. Not now that they were finally together, and nothing could pull them apart again.

Chapter End Notes

And there it is, the end! Thank you so so much if you've read up to this point, that's seriously so cool and I hope you enjoyed it a little bit! This is I think my first properly finished fic that I don't dislike which is awesome sauce. This was a little bit of a writing exercise for me if you could call it that, I'd like to think it helped me to improve my writing for future projects and such! Also an FYI, this chapter was written around the same time as the last one and has not been beta read since then so my sincerest apologies for any mistakes or anything that doesn't make sense, I'll get around to doing a proper edit when I've got more time. Anyway, again, thank you so much if you've read thus far and let me know what you thought, I'd really love to know >:) toodles!

End Notes

There will be more catradora to come just hold out for a minute. Let me know what you think maybeee :)

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